Spring Unending

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Prophecy

SU-01

When black grass creeps, the children cry, a thousand fields where dead ones lie.

When thunder roars and dark clouds curl, the earth splits wide, the spirits swirl.

When the dragon glares, birds take flight. Yin twists with Yang, sun and moon unite.

UTTU Office

???: When Huanzhou falls, the immortal descends, granting longevity and the calamity's end.

???: Talk about inspiration! I'm using this as the introduction for my feature article. The mysterious vibe's gonna have them totally glued to the pages!

???: Got a whole lotta other stuff too. Gonna start as soon as I wrap up this fieldwork.

???: Trust me, Ms. Verity. This article's gonna be the star of UTTU's special issue on the East. I guarantee it!

As Reed provides her update, her voice shakes a delicate strand of spider silk before being carried off in the wind.

The two editors nod. One reaches out and gingerly touches the silk before them.

Verity: I think you really have something, Ms. Reed.

Verity: An elliptical rhyme concerning disasters and the secrets of longevity. It's no surprise that adventurers find it so intriguing.

Verity: But stories like this are not all that uncommon. I worry it won't have enough substance to carry our special issue.

Verity: What makes you so sure it's worth a field trip?

Reed: Ah, great question, ma'am. Well, I did some homework. It's not that much to go on, but if you'd just hear me out ...

The wind carries the sounds from the other side faithfully, even the soft noise of her turning pages.

Reed: There's been all kinds of mantic rhymes in China since, like, the dawn of recorded history, a lot of them obscure or ambiguous. Like, uh, here. There's this one about the Zhou dynasty: "He who sells bows and quivers shall bring the collapse of Zhou ..."

Reed: But really, it was the man's adopted daughter who married Emperor Yōu of Zhou and led to the empire's downfall, and she wasn't even the main cause! What I'm saying is, most of these mantic rhymes are laced with veiled analogies. Who knows what they could mean?

Reed: But this one's different—an exact event at an exact location. It's gonna be a breeze finding more details in the local annals. And my informant promised they'd give me more information when I get there.

Reed: So, yeah, this trip could be a bust, but I'll regret it for the rest of my life if I don't get to the bottom of it. So, here I am in Zhu County.

Reed: And guess what I found?

She pauses, savoring the suspense.

Reed: The wind really does slow around here! Only a little, but it for sure does!

The editors exchange surprised looks and lean in.

Barbara: Will you need any further assistance?

Reed: I'm all good for now. But I'll let you guys know.

Reed: First, I've gotta contact my informant and set up a meeting. Then, I'll interview some locals on the street.

Reed: Who knows? We could even find another shelter if things go well.

She's so eager to share her plans that she fails to notice her colleagues have fallen quiet.

Verity: She's always been a go-getter in every life.

Barbara: But I worry for her. You know how obsessed she is about longevity. These clues she found are unlikely to be a coincidence.

Verity: You needn't worry. Reed grew up there, originally. She won't have any trouble getting accustomed.

Verity: But let's keep an eye on her, just to be sure.

The woolly editor holds her worried expression. Verity returns it with a silent pleading glance, motioning toward the still-open silk.

Street, Zhu County

Barbara: Reed? Are you still there?

Barbara: We trust you've made a good decision with this article, but our network isn't stable right now. You'd better ...

The noise from the streets drowns out the rest of her words.

Reed: My bad. Didn't mean to block the way!

Reed: Cool, cool, gotta go! I'm racing against the clock here! Call you later.

Barbara: Watch out ... danger.

Reed: No worries. I'll be careful. Bye bye!

Reed ends the connection, adjusting her spiderweb brooch as she dodges through the crowds of people and passing bikes.

She looks around and spies her goal not far away.

Reed: Hate to hang up on you, Barbara, but I've got, like, no time to do this. Maybe I'll buy her some local delicacies to say sorry.

Reed: Place sure is lively, so many stores, oh my God, and the restaurants! Finally, no more driving to Chinatown to get a decent meal.

Reed: Alright, first things first. Gotta find an Internet cafe to contact the informant. Oh, better get a couple bottles of water too.

The grass-headed editor walks toward the sign across the street.

An electric fan oscillates back and forth, attempting in vain to blow away the heat rising from the road.

Reed rests on a bamboo chair, her hand finding the mouse in a familiar motion.

Endless Stream BBS

She processes the new information, immediately drawing up a mental map of her impending investigation.

Reed: Nice and clear. Let's go.

Reed takes a confident step forward.

Reed: Excuse me. Do you know the way to Jīn's Well? It's under a tree by the Paifang.

Middle-Aged Woman: What well? Never heard of it.

Middle-Aged Woman: If you're looking for scenic spots, go to the outskirts of town. There's a lot of beautiful sculptures and architecture out there.

Middle-Aged Woman: And the Mei trees in the central park are famous. But I don't know anything about a well.

Reed: Oh, thanks. I'll check them out later.

She waves goodbye to the fifteenth kind person she has questioned so far. The information she's been hoping for still fails to arrive.

Standing in the heart of Zhu County, she lets her eyes wander from the new unfinished buildings rising in the east over to the ancient horse-head walls in the west.

Reed: Jianshe Road ...

The street sign's metallic glare blinds her for a moment.

Reed: That's it. I've asked everyone on the street. No well, no stall, no Grandma Wáng.

Reed: There's no way I got the address wrong. Did my informant lie? Not likely. What good would that do them?

Reed: The northern custom house, the Great Buddha Temple, Jianshe Road, Renmin Road ...

The locations feel off to the young editor. Each one seems to have no connection to the others.

Reed: What if these are all old locations? Like, they're names of places from the past?

Elder: Hey, young comrade. What are you doing in the middle of the street?

A voice speaks, bringing a tide of relief that washes over her like soft rain.

Elder: You've been asking around for directions, haven't you? To the bus stop? Just follow me. I'm heading there right now.

Reed: No, no. I'm meeting someone by Jīn's Well. Do you know where that is?

Reed: Could be an old name, like, really, really old. So, if you know of anywhere even kinda similar, that'd be great. Anything will do.

Elder: Jīn's Well, Jīn's Well ... I've lived here almost 60 years and never heard of it.

Reed: Then, it might be more than 60 years old. Maybe a hundred or so?

Elder: 100 years old? You've got to be kidding. Things change so fast. The whole county looks completely different every few decades, let alone a century.

Elder: You're not trying to pull a fast one on me, are you? I thought you needed help.

Reed: No, sorry.

She considers each piece of information, trying to find a path through their mutual confusion.

Reed: Oh, wait, the rhyme! Have you ever heard of this rhyme?

Reed: It's about black grass, thunder, the earth opening up, and an immortal.

Elder: What? A rhyme?

The scorn in his voice is withering.

For a moment, the approaching deadline and her still blank pages seem like a freight train rushing toward her.

Elder: Aren't you a little too old to be searching for things from fairy tales?

Elder: But I have heard it before—an immortal that slept deep beneath Zhu County. In ancient times when the sky shattered and the earth broke apart, they emerged to save the town.

Elder: But the immortal disappeared right after, taking the Method of Longevity with them, and no one has ever figured out where they went.

Elder: Still, grave robbers turn up around here every year. Those troublemakers just won't give up.

Elder: You seem like a bright young lady. Surely you don't buy into this longevity nonsense, right?

A Windblown Reed

SU-02

Reed shoots up from her seat. The storekeeper, half-startled, looks over to her.

Storekeeper: What's wrong? Is that computer acting up again? Don't you worry. I'll have my daughter fix it.

Storekeeper: You look a little pale. Here, have some water.

Hot steam rises up from the plastic cup.

Storekeeper: These newfangled computer things are quite complex, you know. It takes time to understand how they work.

Reed: Thank you, ma'am. Can I ask, do you know of any old gates that are still around here?

Reed: Even if there's just a bit of wall left, or even a single brick! Anything!

The storekeeper looks puzzled. But eventually she gestures with her chin into the distance.

Storekeeper: An old gate? You must've been too busy to notice it before. Over there.

Storekeeper: It's just a gate like any other. Why do you ask?

Reed: Hmm.

Reed: I'll have another pack of water, ma'am. Can I stay here for a couple more hours?

Even against the deep darkness, Reed can still make out the shape of the tall building.

She rubs her eyes and looks around.

Everything is still. Even the wind has stopped.

Reed: It's late, but this must be the place. The wind's definitely slowing down around here.

Reed: *sigh* Barbara's right. There's gotta be a reason for this interference in the network.

Reed sighs and rubs the yellowing grass on her head.

Reed: I'm totally running out of time. Whoever's behind this, I gotta confront them STAT.

Reed: I guess I might miss the article deadline, but I can still solve the interface issue. That counts as a win, right?

Her grass blades sway as she watches a spider descending down a strand of web.

Reed brushes the silk with her finger.

Reed: The wind doesn't hover in place for no reason, let alone get tangled up.

Reed: So, if it gets tied up in a knot like this, there's gotta be some kind of special power making it stick.

Reed: That power clings to any wind that passes by. The closer the wind is to the knot, the slower it becomes. So, all I need to do is ...

Reed: Find the spot where the wind's moving slowest.

Reed: *gasp* Over there!

She cries out with joy only to realize her surroundings as she ducks her head in embarrassment.

Reed: Oops, sorry. I'll try to keep it down.

Luckily, at night here in this quiet neighborhood, Reed seems to be the only one awake.

She grabs her flashlight and walks out toward the gate.

Reed: It's close. Lemme feel for the wind again.

She reaches out her hand, but this time no silk appears.

Reed: Hmm?

A breeze stirs the grass on her head.

It carries broken sobs, then the bell of an approaching bike.

Reed: I knew you'd come! C'mon! Show yourself!

Her flashlight beam sweeps the area, but it doesn't find her expected foe.

Reed: You're OneWithFlow, right?

Reed: Wait. What if they aren't even human?

Her spirits lift a little.

Reed: I've gotta dig deeper. This'll totally make the article—

Reed: Ah!

Something warm and heavy presses against her leg, letting out a cry like a baby.

She looks down, shocked. A bike bell rings behind her.

Reed: Alright, my bad. I shouldn't have broken into your place.

Reed: I'll leave, I promise. Just gimme a sec.

Reed angles her flashlight downward, taking notice of a faint mark on the stone wall.

Reed: Are those carvings?

Reed: Let me see. "Step into our gate, and gain eternity. From the hands of the immortal, law descends—no calamity, no end."

Reed: Bingo. Finally, something concrete.

She takes a few steps forward, her left hand reaching for the spiderweb brooch on her chest.

Reed: Hello? I've got some amazing findings to report. There's an old gate in town where the wind's almost totally frozen.

Reed: Hello? Barbara? Ms. Verity?

She finds a familiar silence as she nears the wall. The spider lies dormant and still.

Reed: Huh, it was pretty windy when those Carbuncles popped out. They must've disturbed the air.

Reed: Can't get any connection on the spider as is. Guess I've gotta make some wind myself.

She switches off her light.

Reed: Here goes.

She stomps her foot, and a familiar bike bell sounds nearby.

Reed silently apologizes to the small creatures.

Reed: Next, guide the wind to untie the knot.

Reed: What?

Her body stiffens.

Everything vanishes. Sound, light, even smell disappear as the void swallows her whole.

Until an unfamiliar voice cuts through the darkness.

???: Want to try mine?

The wind sweeps her up and pulls her toward the voice, then stops and plummets.

"The Gate to Longevity"

SU-03

???: Go on, have a taste.

Reed: Who's there?

Reclining Lady: I was certain you'd been dying to try the clear soup, Mayfly.

Reed: Clear soup?

From the reflection in the bowl, Reed sees a frown on a face that doesn't belong to her. Through that reflection's eyes, she notices a white rim of sugar that rounds the bowl.

Mayfly: You just poured a whole potful of sugar in, Paper Heron. You can hardly even call it clear soup anymore. Eugh, what a waste.

Paper Heron: Aha, really? I think it could use a touch more.

Noise fills her head. Cold seeps through her clothes. Rough cloth rubs against her skin. The air spiced with the comfortable smell of wet dirt.

Boy I: *whining* Mama, my hands are cold.

Ancient Woman I: Cold or not, you don't press your hands against someone's neck! It's rude.

Ancient Man I: I'm visiting my cousin. Heard there will be something special at the fair this year.

Vendor I: Classic Zhu snacks for only three wen! Only three wen!

Reed: Zhu County? But, this looks totally different.

City Gate, Ancient Zhu County

Mayfly: You want more? Have you ... Have you lost your taste, Heron?

Paper Heron: Not just my taste, all my senses. That's why I roam the land, see? I'm seeking a cure.

Mayfly: Then, you're here to see the immortal too?

Paper Heron: Ah, no, merely seeking a companion of mine. She does have the look of an immortal, though I couldn't say for sure whether she is one.

Paper Heron: But tell me about this immortal you seek.

Mayfly thinks for a moment, then continues shyly.

Mayfly: Honestly, I know very little about them. All I've heard is that an immortal is supposed to come to the fair this year to teach people the Method of Longevity.

Mayfly: They say it grants both a long life and lasting health.

Mayfly: Its results are said to be remarkable. An old granny learned it, and now she can swim the Nanfei River back and forth, even during winter.

Mayfly: Maybe it's the cure you're looking for too!

Paper Heron: Sounds intriguing. I'll be sure to keep an eye out.

Paper Heron: But why the hushed voice?

Mayfly looks around anxiously.

Mayfly: Because the guards might hear me. The magistrate posted a notice saying the rumor's false; anyone who spreads it will be punished.

Paper Heron: Hmm, words do carry weight. Rumors can grow out of control if left unchecked.

Mayfly: True.

Mayfly: Still, it's drawn all sorts to Zhu County. Just look at the line behind us. Some told me they came all the way from Liaodong, far in the frozen north.

Paper Heron: Is that so? Good for them, eh?

Mayfly: Shhh! Keep your voice down. Aren't you afraid of the guards?

Mayfly: You're a Daoist. They'll search you head to toe.

Mayfly: I heard all manner of folk are trying to sneak into the town, the kinds that'll do anything for the Method of Longevity.

Mayfly: There've even been deaths. See those guards? They're checking every traveler looking for vagrants, Yao, and criminals. Speak of the Method, and you'll be locked away in an instant.

Mayfly: That's why they're so strict. They've even got Reversion Bells to magically identify us Yao.

Mayfly: But I think those things only work on the dull-witted ones. Quite a few have slipped through already.

Paper Heron: Reversion Bells only reveal a Yao's true face. They cannot tell virtue from vice.

Paper Heron: Yet there are things that can: truth potions, the Immortal's Brush, even some arcane beasts.

Paper Heron: Hmm? You're not listening, Mayfly. Take a breath. All will be well.

Mayfly: Eugh, frost take me. I don't need a magic lesson right now.

Mayfly shakes her head, letting her gaze rest on Paper Heron's mule.

Mayfly: Hey, you've got a lot of stuff packed up on that mule. You selling those things at the fair?

Paper Heron: No, I wanted to get a gift for my friend, but I'm not so sure of her taste, so I bought whatever caught my eye. I'll let her choose whatever she likes.

Mayfly: Is this a snow lotus carving? Did you find it in the Western Regions?

Caught up in the excitement of this new sight, Mayfly can't help but start asking questions, her tone alive with interest.

Mayfly: What was it like there? Is it as beautiful as they say? Please, tell me all about it.

Paper Heron: Ah, the view was breathtaking. Standing at the cliff's edge, watching the world turn white with the falling snow. I didn't even realize where I was. My mule carried me there, see?

Paper Heron: The Western Regions, hmm, to the west, then? Where exactly is that?

Paper Heron's eyes dart upward, forward, side-to-side, until they look like a needle on a broken compass.

Mayfly: *sigh*

Mayfly: I almost forgot how hopeless you are with directions. Lucky I found you on your way here, or rather, on your way somewhere else entirely.

Mayfly: Never mind. Let's get back in line.

She doesn't wait for a response. Mayfly looks over the crowd toward the city gate, her fingers rubbing a hidden object in the folds of her clothes.

There's a low current of unease that runs through the crowd. As if they were moving along a treacherous bridge, each shift of their feet cautious as heads bob side-to-side, checking for movement.

It doesn't move. For a time, it feels like it has never moved at all. Each person taking their turn to sigh as they look ahead with a worried expression.

Mayfly: *sigh* How much longer must we wait? I'll start growing roots if this line doesn't budge.

Ancient Man I: Move forward, will you?

Constable I: Get moving! Those who passed the cargo check must go to the Reversion Bell! Hurry it up. There's a whole line behind you!

Constable I: Next!

The impatient constable gestures for the static line to advance.

Mayfly: I'll be next.

Mayfly squeezes the little object tight beneath her robes as she edges forward.

Constable I: What's that you have tucked in your sleeve? It looks solid.

Mayfly: N-Nothing, officer.

Constable I: Hands in the air. Give—

A cry comes from up ahead, causing both of them to turn their heads.

Mayfly: What happened?

A bronze bell rings, its noise emanating from a man at the front of the line, the vibrations pressing him into the ground.

Civilian I: Aghh.

Civilian II: Claws. His hands are turning into claws!

Under the bell's power, the man transforms into a large yellow dog, its features fiendish, its fangs sharp.

Yellow Dog: *roar*

Civilian II: Run! It's a Yao! Run!

Constable II: Capture that monster! Don't let it get away!

Civilian III: Stop pushing! Someone fell down here!

Mayfly: Hey. Stop-Stop pushing!

Mayfly: Where's the Yao? Where?

Paper Heron: Eight views merge, the mystery of Qi. Three lights darken, and all lose their way.

Mayfly: W-What?

Mayfly: Heron, wh-what was that spell? I feel woozy.

Paper Heron: Come on. Hop up.

Mayfly: What's happening? I ...

Paper Heron: We can't let that yellow dog tear through the crowd.

Paper Heron: I'll subdue it before harm comes to anyone. Easy now, big fellow.

Yellow Dog: Roar!!!

Paper Heron: Ah, you're tougher than I thought.

Paper Heron: Show me what you've got.

???: Who is responsible for this mayhem?

Yellow Dog: *whimper*

A young man in an officer's uniform knocks the yellow dog out with a single strike. As it crumples to the ground, he turns his blade toward Paper Heron now seated on her mule.

???: Causing chaos at the city gate, are we? Looking for trouble?

Paper Heron: Your most discerning lordship, I swear on all that is good. 'Twas he who started it.

???: Hmph. Was there really any need for all this?

The officer's token hangs plainly and openly on his belt, tempting Paper Heron to begin reading its inscription aloud without thinking.

Paper Heron: Patrol Bureau of Zhu County, Chief Constable, Chéng Héguāng.

Cheng Heguang: At your service.

Cheng Heguang: Dù Liù, stay and maintain order. Yáng Wǔ, arrest this Daoist. Ensure she lifts the spell before you put her away. I will question her personally.

Du Liu & Yang Wu: Understood!

The spell's force lingers in the air. The others at the gate remain dazed as the world spins.

Dù Liù and Yáng Wǔ push their way through the confused crowd.

Civilian II: Aah. Where am I? Is this heaven?

Civilian III: Wait. What happened to the money in my purse? Did that dog curse my sight?

Mayfly: Ah, don't look at me. I didn't do anything.

Constable II: Damned yellow dog! You won't get away from us!

A dazed constable holds the Reversion Bell as he stumbles into the crowd.

Mayfly: Eh?

Under the bell's power, Mayfly's human form disappears.

In its place appears a wilting tuft of grass.

Paper Heron: Oh, no!

Reed: Wait, she's a ...?

Acting on pure instinct, Reed calls out, but the scene before her dissolves away like mist.

A light wind rustles her hair. Zhu County feels the first chill winds of autumn.

Without realizing it, she has left the gate tower and found herself walking alone through the dark streets.

Reed: The wind can hold on to information for a long time, so I'm guessing that knot must've been here for ages. Then, that must have been Mayfly's memory?

Reed: Her true form was a tuft of reed, just like me.

Reed: It was already winter, though; she would've been running out of time.

She thinks of the calendar in her notebook. Over three hundred boxes, two-thirds crossed out.

Reed: Then, my informant from the forum ... Could it be her?

Summer's Lease

SU-04

Inn, Zhu County

Reed sits quietly by the bed.

No sign of her spider friend. No glow from the brooch on her chest.

She has walked every street in the city but never found an answer. It was all in vain.

Reed: Nope, wind's still giving me nothing.

A few dry leaves break off from her head, drifting toward her pillow.

Reed: Maybe I should leave so I can contact Ms. Verity and then decide if I want to head back.

Reed: No. It's all too suspicious. She'd tell me to abort, for sure.

Reed: *sigh* Basically, I should give up and just go back to headquarters. I could pick another topic to work on if I still have time.

How much time do you have left?

Reed: Time. Hah. Like I've ever had that.

The budding writer lets out a short laugh at her own expense as she picks up a fallen leaf from the bed and smooths it flat.

Reed: Winter's coming.

Reed: I'll have withered by then. Even if another reed'll sprout from my body next year, "I" will be gone for good.

Reed: The inevitable end of every ephemeral plant.

Reed: Mayfly ... She was one of us. I wonder what happened to her. Did she find a way to keep on living?

Reed: Hrmph.

Reed: I can't. I just can't accept that I'll die without finishing my article, especially when I'm, like, a single step away from finding a way to stay me.

She places the blade of grass between the pages of her notebook.

Reed: That's that. I just need to keep going. Besides, these knots are an anomaly that needs to be fixed anyway; why shouldn't I be the one to do it?

Reed: Alright, forget about whatever this OneWithFlow's trying. I'll just do my thing.

Reed: I-I have to finish this article.

Reed closes her notebook and steps out the door.

Once more, the wind seems to pull at her, nearly tearing her mind straight out of her body. The gust leaves behind an uneasy feeling in her stomach.

She bears the feeling and waits for the fall she knows is coming.

Reed: Is this another of Mayfly's memories?

A brief sadness rises in her, then a faintly familiar voice cuts it off.

???: Chief?

???: May I enter?

Cheng Heguang: Please.

City Defense Office, Ancient Zhu County

After settling the disturbance, Dù Liù makes his way to the town's constabulary office and knocks at the door of his chief.

At the desk, Chéng Héguāng bends over a mess of documents.

Du Liu: Sir, the Daoist has lifted the spell. Several people in the crowd were injured by that yellow dog; we've sent them to get treatment.

Du Liu: Order has been restored at the gate. Inspections are ongoing.

Du Liu: The Daoist and her mule are locked up. She's ready for interrogation. Yáng Wǔ is watching her.

The chief nods, barely looking up from his files.

Cheng Heguang: Good. Return to your position. I will go to see her immediately.

Dù Liù looks down over the papers, letting out an unintended grumble as he realizes their meaning.

Du Liu: Ah. Forgive me, Chief, but isn't that someone else's job? I fail to see why we should bother investigating these animal carcasses. I know the Stilted Parade is about to begin, but—

Cheng Heguang: You understand the importance of this for the people, do you not? We must leave no stone unturned.

Du Liu: Yes, but even so, it seems a waste of our men's time to look into a few dead animals?

Du Liu: There's no proof that they were killed by Yao. Perhaps it was some beasts in the mountain that chased them here.

Du Liu: And even if it was a Yao, there's no need to take it so seriously. It's best to leave them to their own affairs.

Cheng Heguang: "Their own affairs"?

Cheng Heguang: All residents of the Ming Empire, be they human or Yao, are bound under the same law, and it is our duty to uphold it.

Cheng Heguang: You know as well as I do that something is afoot here. Those carcasses are involved in all this. I can feel it.

He points at the file in his hand.

Cheng Heguang: This report just reached me. Another carcass was found in Chunhua Alley this morning.

Cheng Heguang: Like the others, it was intact, yet pale and dry. There were also sightings of the same mysterious parade near the scene.

Cheng Heguang: They were spreading rumors about the Method of Longevity. They have already amassed a small following.

Cheng Heguang: And do not forget Commander Lì's orders: we must make sure the fair is without blemish. This risk is too large to ignore.

Du Liu: But, Chief Chéng, the men have been working for weeks without rest. They're exhausted. If we give them more work—

Dù Liù doesn't have time to finish his complaint before another knock interrupts him.

Constable I: Chief, Yáng Wǔ is expecting you.

Cheng Heguang: Understood. I'll be there shortly.

His subordinate decides to bite back his words.

Du Liu: I must go. Excuse me, Chief.

Cheng Heguang: Hold on! Hmm.

Dù Liù waits, already expecting his next words.

Cheng Heguang: I, hmm, I know that everyone has been working hard of late, and I am sincerely grateful for their efforts.

He stumbles to find the right words.

Cheng Heguang: So, let them know, once the fair is over, I will take them to the finest restaurant in town.

Cheng Heguang: My treat.

Du Liu: Much appreciated. But I'm certain even a chief's salary couldn't cover such a meal.

Du Liu: I'll have their bellies filled before we go. We wouldn't want to embarrass you, huh?

Cheng Heguang: No need. The chef there is a friend. They won't charge me much if I bring the ingredients myself. Bass is in season.

Du Liu: Oh, you're bringing bass? I'll tell the men to skip lunch then.

Du Liu: Still the record holder of the Fishing Competition, aren't you? Who else but Chéng could pull up a bass half his size?

Cheng Heguang: Please, Dù Liù, it's just a way to make some extra wen. Right, enough talk. Back to work.

Du Liu: Yes, Chief Chéng! I'll take my leave then.

He leaves, and the young officer returns to his files.

The mist rises again, covering the scene before her and then dissolving away.

The darkness is familiar now. She waits for the inn's open window to return to her sight.

Reed: That wasn't Mayfly's memory. How many people are involved in this story? Are they somehow connected to each other?

???: Perhaps this will make things clearer.

Reed: ...!

Wind screams past her, pulling her again toward some distant, unknown place.

Her thoughts sink first, spreading like roots digging into the earth. Then, a nursery rhyme lifts them up.

Free at Last

SU-05

Children: When black grass creeps, the children cry, a thousand fields where dead ones lie.

Children: When thunder roars and dark clouds curl, the earth splits wide, the spirits swirl.

Jail, Ancient Zhu County

Paper Heron: Hmm? A local rhyme from Huanzhou, isn't it?

In the cell, Paper Heron listens with interest to the distant children's voices. Her mule chews straw on the floor, unconcerned with their present state of affairs.

Beside her, Mayfly strains on her tiptoes at the small cell window, her face a contortion of overlapping anxieties.

Mayfly: It's only been a few hours since we came in, and they've already captured another five Yao. We're doomed.

She turns dejectedly and leans against the cell's earthen wall.

After a moment of brooding silence, she yanks the once-cherished object from her pocket and flings it to the ground.

Mayfly: Liar! You wretched, dirty liar!

Mayfly: That merchant swore his trinket could fool the Reversion Bell, but it didn't. I spent all I had on it.

Mayfly: And that wretched yellow dog. If it hadn't made such a scene, I might have slipped right past. I hate you. I hate you all!

Mayfly: *sob* I'm such a fool.

Paper Heron: Now, now. They'll release us soon. We only need to wait.

Paper Heron smiles, looking first at the distraught Mayfly, then toward the trampled amulet on the floor.

Paper Heron: And, for the record, your amulet is not a fake. Its power is merely too weak to silence the Reversion Bell without a spell. It could be that the merchant forgot to tell you.

Paper Heron: You're no fool. No one's to blame.

Mayfly: A-Are you defending him? D-Don't you see how miserable I am?

Paper Heron: Now, now, we'll be just fine. They can't keep us locked away forever.

She picks up the amulet while murmuring a few words, then dusts it off, and hands it back to Mayfly.

Paper Heron: Here, take this. Might prove useful.

Mayfly: Get that away from me!

Paper Heron: All right, all right, no need to fear. Remember that spell I cast on you? Now they'll see you as just a bundle of hay. I'll pick you up and take you with me when I'm freed.

Mayfly: *sigh* I never should have come here.

The offer does little to lift her spirits. The grass ornament in her hair droops over, matching her defeated expression.

Paper Heron, by contrast, seems completely unbothered by their predicament. Instead, her eyes are fixed on a stone in the corner of her cell.

A moment passes before she lets out a cry of delight.

Paper Heron: And done!

Mayfly: W-What?

Paper Heron moves in a flourish, presenting the stone to her companion.

It now bears a carving that reads, "Mayfly and Paper Heron were here."

Paper Heron: Well, there isn't much else to do cooped up in here. How do you like it, eh?

Mayfly looks at the stone brick still dusted with debris. The grooves of the carving match the width of Paper Heron's finger.

Mayfly: Did you carve that with your nails?

Paper Heron: Haha, no. Just a little trick I picked up on the road—carving with air. Not mastered yet, mind you. Not exactly fit for the emperor, haha. Anything else you'd have me add?

Mayfly: That's all? That's what you use your arcane skills for?

Paper Heron: Hm? Of course not. I'm capable of much more than this.

Bent over, Paper Heron makes a gesture with her right hand. As she does, a line of sharp white Qi wraps around her finger. As she begins moving her finger through the air, the form of a reed plant etches itself into the stone.

Paper Heron: See? It's you! Quite the way to mark the moment, eh?

It doesn't seem to ease her new friend's concerns.

Mayfly: Heron, no! You turned me into a bundle of hay, remember? They'll know it was me.

Paper Heron: Ah! You're right. I'll undo it at once.

Paper Heron: For a moment, I thought that our names might be here for all to see for the next ten thousand years, not mere minutes.

Mayfly: Wait.

She stops Paper Heron's hand with a firm shake of her head.

Mayfly: Leave it.

Paper Heron: Hmm?

Mayfly: It'll be a keepsake, like you said. If someone a thousand years from now see it and know I was here ...

Mayfly: Well, that wouldn't be so bad.

Her voice seems to echo as if coming from some hollow void within her.

Paper Heron studies her young friend. Thoughts flutter across her eyes until she nods and smiles.

Paper Heron: Very well. Now stop your fretting.

A set of hurried footsteps comes from afar.

Paper Heron: They're coming. Hush. I'll slip you into my sleeve.

Paper Heron utters an incantation. In an instant, Mayfly transforms into a paper figure that she slips into her sleeve.

Yang Wu: Chief Chéng, she's in there.

The two constables open the cell door, barging inside before coming to a stop directly in front of Paper Heron.

Yang Wu: You claimed to be a Daoist. Where's your certificate?

Paper Heron: Here.

The chief takes her certificate and furrows his brow as he reads. He looks from the certificate to Paper Heron and then to the mule.

Yang Wu: Issued in the Hongwu era? That's over 100 years ago!

Cheng Heguang: Daoists cultivate themselves for longevity. It's only natural she looks younger than she is.

Yáng Wǔ stares at Paper Heron in wide-mouthed disbelief, but the chief has already moved on from those minor details.

Cheng Heguang: What is your relationship with the plant spirit that was revealed at the gate?

Paper Heron: I have no relationship with her at all. We simply happened to be in line at the same time. I didn't even know she was a Yao.

He does not reply but glances up at Paper Heron, then back at the certificate.

Paper Heron: Oh! Do I need a certificate for my mule too?

Cheng Heguang: Is your mule a Daoist?

Paper Heron: No.

Cheng Heguang: Then no.

Yang Wu: Heh. What kind of interrogation is this?

Completing his check with a resigned nod, Chéng Héguāng returns the certificate to Paper Heron.

Cheng Heguang: Certificate's clear. You may go, but don't make any more trouble, or there will be consequences.

Paper Heron: Not to worry, officer. I always keep to the straight and narrow.

He shifts his focus from the woman to the nearby cell.

Cheng Heguang: Where's the plant spirit?

Yang Wu: In the next cell. Hasn't turned back to her human form yet. I think she's playing dead.

As the two men walk over to the next cell, Paper Heron leads her mule out from the dark, damp place.

Paper Heron: Here we are, free once more. Feeling alright?

Finding a quiet spot, the paper figure drifts from Paper Heron's sleeve and, in a puff of smoke, returns Mayfly to her familiar form.

Paper Heron: Didn't I say that all would work out just fine?

Mayfly: Hmm. Mmm.

Mayfly: It's not much fun being a piece of paper. I couldn't see or hear much of anything, and my body was so flat.

Mayfly: I think I heard something about the Hongwu era?

Paper Heron: Haha, my Daoist certificate, long expired. Fortunate for us, the constable was too dull to notice.

Paper Heron: Tell me, what do you plan to do in town? I hope our delay has not brought you trouble.

Mayfly: Well, ah, oh right, are you hungry, Heron?

She points to a nearby stall. The street has swelled with people, and as the crowd grows, the stall owners call out all the louder for attention.

A line has formed around a set of steaming bamboo baskets. Mayfly slips into the crowd of eager customers.

Mayfly: *sigh* I haven't eaten since this morning. I should've had that clear soup.

Stall Owner I: Here's your sweet olive cake, fresh from the steamer.

Mayfly: Thank you. *sniff* Smells divine.

She cannot wait and takes a bite. A soft, sweet scent fills the air, and a sigh of pure contentment follows.

Mayfly: Mm, mm. It's ... It's so good.

Paper Heron: Really? It's only cake.

Mayfly: I can't help it. It's sweet, tender, chewy. You must try it.

She smiles and hands Paper Heron a sweet olive cake, still hot to the touch. Paper Heron looks it over, then delicately lifts it to her mouth.

Mayfly: So? So? Isn't it wonderful?

Paper Heron: Mmm. Hmm. The texture is quite remarkable.

She chews with effort, searching for the vaunted taste within.

Paper Heron: Mmm. I think ...

Mayfly: What? What??

She watches Mayfly as she chews, each bite meeting waves of rapture, and attempts to mimic her delight. Somehow, the act of imitation seems to conjure the promised flavors.

Paper Heron: I think it's sweet, and it grows sweeter and sweeter the more I chew.

Mayfly: Right?

Paper Heron: Mmm. It's good, delicious. I must get some more. Mm. Here, eat up, Mayfly.

Stall Owner I: You two must be visitors. Are you here for the fair?

Paper Heron: *burp* That's right. Heard it would be quite the spectacle.

Stall Owner I: It certainly will be. And thanks to that rumor, business is going great this year.

Paper Heron: What makes this year so special, hm?

Stall Owner I: Well, many religious sects have flourished in Zhu County recently, each one claiming to bring longevity to their followers. All just tall tales, of course.

Stall Owner I: Only this time is different. Well, it's hearsay. But many think the reason the fair is so busy this year is that one of the sponsors found a true immortal.

Mayfly: I heard that too. My friend said her friend's grandfather, who'd been buried, suddenly came home alive, saying he was enlightened by an immortal in Zhu County.

Stall Owner I: And they say tonight's opera is in fact an opening ceremony for the immortal's sect. They've even widened the stage.

Paper Heron: Ah. Sounds impressive.

Stall Owner I: And not just that. Have you noticed the constables? I've never seen them so nervous. I'd say ...

Paper Heron: Hmm. But these are mere fancies. Is there nothing we can see with our own eyes?

Stall Owner I: Certainly, the Stilted Parade.

Mayfly: Oh, the Stilted Parade.

Paper Heron: The event you mentioned on the way here, isn't it?

Mayfly: Yes! I heard it's great fun. Where can we see it?

Stall Owner I: Right behind you.

The stall owner closes the steamer and slips back into the storefront.

It's only now that they realize how quiet the street had become. Not a soul in sight, until a strange, dense bank of perfumed air rolls past them.

Mayfly: Hmm?

Deadly Cure

SU-06

The sky grows dim above them. A low, haunting chant drifts up into the air. Curious, Mayfly looks toward the end of the street.

Mayfly: Oh, right, the parade's coming.

A crowded wave of people surges into view from the distance. Mayfly cranes her neck, straining to see.

Chant: Withered grass devours bone. On icy plain the spirits moan.

Chant: When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.

The unearthly parade advances; a line of towering figures leads its approach in long, otherworldly strides. It takes a moment to spot the stilts as they push against the fabric with each step.

Mayfly: What are they singing?

Woman I: Withered grass devours bone. On icy plain the spirits moan.

Mayfly: What is ...

The parade is near. Their chanting pours over Mayfly like a flood of divine music.

"Immortal" I: When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.

All: When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.

A fox and a woman have appeared over Mayfly's shoulder. Their hushed voices brushing against her ear.

Woman I: We sit at the bottom of society, but still, we deserve dignity. One Yao's voice may not be heard, but what of a hundred or even a thousand more?

Mayfly: W-Who are you? What do you want?

Fox: Same as you, we are Yao.

Fox: You've seen them bat us off, even kill us, haven't you? Will you continue to suffer in silence? Will you live on in fear?

Woman I: We need to fight. Fight for our lives! Save our people and claim the Method of Longevity for our own! Overthrow humans and rule the world!

Fox: Come, join us! If we are doomed, then we will doom them with us!

Mayfly: No. I-I ...

She looks around, hoping to find help, only to realize she is surrounded by thick billows of scented fog.

Woman I: Those that are not with us are the enemy.

Woman I: Did they ever show you mercy? Then, why hesitate?

White fur sprouts from her nose, revealing the Yao to be a hare.

Her feet begin to stamp like war drums. The other Yao watch, then look at one another. All of them feeling the pull to join in.

Hare: The Immortal will grant us longevity!

All Yao: The Immortal will grant us longevity!

Yao I: Constables! Run!

Mayfly: What?

As they round the mouth of the alley, the parade vanishes as quickly as it appeared. The chanting music fades like smoke in the air.

Paper Heron: Mayfly? Can you hear me? You were caught in the parade's illusion. I had to lead you away.

Mayfly: I-I'm alright now. Those Yao—they're seeking longevity.

Paper Heron: Yes.

Paper Heron: But what they're doing is a risk to our entire community.

Mayfly looks down, her face turning red. Finally deciding something, she stamps her foot.

Mayfly: Paper Heron, thank you for bringing me here. I owe you much, so I don't want to lie anymore. I ...

Paper Heron tilts her head, looking puzzled but relieved.

Paper Heron: Lie about what?

Mayfly: You know my true form is a tuft of reed. I'm a Yao, just like the others in the parade.

Mayfly: In truth, the reason I came all this way is to seek the Method of Longevity. I lied because, well, I feared you'd hate me. I'm sorry.

Mayfly: But I don't want to hurt anyone. I just wanna live longer. Even a little would do.

Paper Heron: Hush. You'll hear no judgment from me. Only, I don't understand.

Paper Heron: You risked a lifetime of confinement on a rumor. Is longevity really so important to you?

Mayfly: ...

She goes quiet for a moment, then looks down.

Mayfly: Remember the travelers we met on the way here? Human or Yao, all sought the Method of Longevity.

Mayfly: But you're different. You care more for the small joys in life, like that sweet olive cake we shared.

Mayfly: It's almost as if you don't care about how long you'll live at all.

Paper Heron: Ah ...

Paper Heron: I'm not so unlike you. I suppose I'm just curious about everything.

Paper Heron: We're already here. Why hurry? If we'd missed that cake, we'd have regretted it for the rest of our lives.

Paper Heron scratches her head as she tries to explain; words rest on her tongue, but they feel, like her, suddenly out of place.

Mayfly: ...

Mayfly: *sigh* You win.

She brushes her skirt and sighs.

Mayfly: Sorry, I shouldn't have been so suspicious of you.

Mayfly: Though we study arcanum and can take human shapes, we Yao are still just plants and animals. Even if we look like you, our lives are much shorter.

Mayfly: Reeds like me sprout in spring and wither in winter. My entire life begins and ends in less than a year.

Mayfly: I know it's foolish to risk so much on a rumor, but it's all I have.

Mayfly: Do you know what I think when the sun sets? Not that the sky is lovely, but that I lost another day. I don't want to live in fear anymore.

Paper Heron: But you spent all you had on that amulet.

Paper Heron: What if the Method of Longevity proves false? You'll have nothing left.

Mayfly smiles, but she lets her eyes stay downcast for a moment before they rise to meet her own.

Mayfly: Longevity means much more to me than you, Heron. When the winter ends, you will see the spring, and I won't.

Mayfly: If the Method is true, it will change everything. I have to take the chance, no matter the cost.

Mayfly: And as you said yourself, I have nothing left to lose.

They share a long gaze. Paper Heron reads the dark eyes before her. They seem to burn like unsettled coal.

Paper Heron: Mayfly ...

The usually free-spirited Daoist is, for a moment, speechless. She intends to speak, but then the unexpected strikes.

Serious Male Voice: Commander!

The familiar voice comes from around the corner, seizing her train of thought.

Paper Heron: Hmm?

Cheng Heguang: Commander, I come with an urgent report.

Separate Ways

SU-07

Paper Heron: Shush! Someone's here. Get in my sleeve.

Paper Heron gives the mule's rump a light slap. It brays as it ambles behind a nearby haystack.

She presses close to the wall and peers out at the two men. One familiar, the other unfamiliar and bearing greater authority.

Cheng Heguang: Commander Lì.

Li Huifeng: Such hurried words, Chéng. What's the matter?

Cheng Heguang: It's concerning an unusual parade that has been seen moving through the town. The marchers chanted strange words and even tempted townsfolk to join their ranks.

Cheng Heguang: But they vanished as soon as our men arrived. This is the fourth such incident in as many weeks.

Li Huifeng: Go on.

Cheng Heguang: Sometimes they leave animal carcasses in their wake. I've ordered a search. Our men may discover something soon.

Cheng Heguang: These animals are unusual. They bear no marks of either hunting or natural death. It appears to be some sort of ritual slaughter.

Cheng Heguang: They're the ones that have been spreading those rumors about the Method of Longevity. Many townsfolk have joined with them. I fear ...

Li Huifeng: You would have me redirect men that already stretched thin to chase down a parade.

Li Huifeng: Which, so far, has done little more than leave a few dead animals behind. Do I understand you correctly?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Chéng Héguāng's face turns red. He wants to say something, but the words come out in a fluster.

Cheng Heguang: All of these events are linked together with the Stilted Parade, and—

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, what are the orders I've given you?

Cheng Heguang: To maintain order, keep criminals from the county, and to see our people enjoy the fair in safety.

Li Huifeng: And how do you judge your performance?

Cheng Heguang: I have done my utmost, Commander.

Li Huifeng: Yet there was a disturbance at the gate.

Cheng Heguang: I cannot deny it.

Li Huifeng: The Stilted Parade is the most significant event of the year, an opportunity for people to laugh and be merry after a year of hard work.

Li Huifeng: It's our duty to maintain peace so that they may enjoy the festival.

Li Huifeng: But with all the visitors flooding into the county, we are already short on men.

Li Huifeng: You know well that they have been working day and night. Many haven't seen their own homes in days.

Cheng Heguang: I know, Commander.

Li Huifeng: No, you do not. While your men are out dealing with these visitors and all their other duties—

Li Huifeng: You come to ask that I direct them to another task based on groundless suspicions?

Cheng Heguang: My apologies, Commander.

Li Huifeng: *sigh* Raise your head. Listen. You are pushing yourself too hard, Héguāng.

Cheng Heguang: ...

Noticing his protégé's dejected silence, the stern commander softens his tone, if only ever-so-slightly.

Li Huifeng: I know how eager you are to prove yourself. Any man in your position would be.

Li Huifeng: And I know it was I who told you to work ten or a hundred times harder to earn your place, given your father's history.

Li Huifeng: But true diligence must rest in stability. There are no shortcuts.

Li Huifeng: Many eyes are on you, Héguāng. If you truly wish to wash your family name of its dishonor, let them find no fault in you.

Li Huifeng: Do your duty first, then take the next step. That is how things are done.

Cheng Heguang: I understand.

He keeps his face pointed down, averting his commander's stare. Lì Huìfēng thinks for a moment and clears his throat.

Li Huifeng: Ahem. Your father disgraced himself when he threw his lot in with those bandits, but that does not mean you will follow his path.

Li Huifeng: You must not let the whispers of others shake your heart.

Li Huifeng: Do you remember why I recruited you? Because I saw a young man with the integrity and conviction to truly protect people.

Li Huifeng: I still do.

Lì Huìfēng pats the young officer on the shoulder, then returns his hands stiffly behind his back.

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, your future is bright. Work hard, and you will surely rise to the top, and your family name will be cleared.

Cheng Heguang: Understood.

Li Huifeng: I have other matters to attend to. Think carefully on my words.

Cheng Heguang: I will, Commander.

Watching from the wall, Paper Heron sees the young man standing motionless. For a moment, he seems so stiff that he could be a wood carving.

Paper Heron: The other one's left. What's he waiting for, hm?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Suddenly, Chéng Héguāng lifts his foot and kicks a pebble away.

Mule: Whinny?

Cheng Heguang: Who's there?

Mule: Whinny?

Meeting the sound with calm and precise motion, he summons a hundred leaves that circle the mule; in that same instant, they take on a fearsome steel glint.

Paper Heron: Uh-oh!

Paper Heron: You go ahead, Mayfly. I can't leave that stupid mule behind.

She picks up Mayfly's paper form with her left hand. With her right, she makes a gesture to break the incantation, then breathes a soft puff of air that sends her floating away.

Paper Heron watches as her friend drifts out of reach before leaping to the top of a nearby elm and hiding among the leaves.

Now only one man and one mule remain.

Mule: Bray—

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. That Daoist must be around.

Cheng Heguang: But her trail ends here. Where did she go?

Chéng Héguāng looks around. He feigns an attack on the mule but stops mid-gesture as he catches a ripple of air from the elm tree above him.

In a flash, Paper Heron stands amidst a newly formed ring of elm-leaf blades.

Cheng Heguang: You won't get away!

Paper Heron: Oops! Should've been more careful.

Paper Heron: Huff, huff. You surely can run, officer.

Cheng Heguang: *panting*

Cheng Heguang: Why were you eavesdropping, you conniving Daoist?

Paper Heron: You must be mistaken, sir. I merely happened to be there.

Cheng Heguang: You happened to be there, did you? After making a scene at the gate this morning? Do you think me born yesterday?

Paper Heron: Ugh, is there any worth in explaining? You're being unreasonable.

Cheng Heguang: You can explain in the interrogation room!

Paper Heron jumps onto the roof and seizes a straight, even branch, blocking an attack from behind.

Paper Heron: Hey, hey, hey! Your blade's sharp! I might have been hurt!

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. My blade is no threat to you! If you have nothing to hide, stop this now and follow me to the Yamen!

Paper Heron: Very well, on one condition.

Cheng Heguang: What?

At that, Paper Heron's eyes light up as she launches into an eager explanation.

Paper Heron: My mule's been limping since it twisted its ankle in the mountain.

Paper Heron: Could you teach it how to run? I think with a little training, you could make a champion out of it.

Cheng Heguang: You ...

Panicked Voice: Chief! Chief!

Yang Wu: There's another disturbance at the gate! Come, quickly!

Paper Heron: Oh?

Chéng Héguāng looks over in surprise to find Yáng Wǔ standing in the street, scratching his head, and then back to Paper Heron, who has stopped a short distance away.

Paper Heron: Told you I'm not the one you should be chasing.

Cheng Heguang: The gate again! Your accomplices, no doubt!

He surges forward on a burst of Qi in pursuit of Paper Heron. Yet, with unhurried ease, she drifts back, maintaining her distance precisely.

Cheng Heguang: Enough!

Chéng Héguāng spins his blade, and all the leaves on the tree become sharp edges.

A humming noise fills the air as the sharp leaves pin Paper Heron against the wall.

Paper Heron: Huh?

Cheng Heguang: I can't let another disturbance reach Commander Lì.

Cheng Heguang: You stay here. I will take you and your accomplices to the Yamen on my return.

Paper Heron: Not to worry, officer. I'll stay right where I am.

Paper Heron: Take my mule if you mistrust me. You know I won't leave it behind.

Paper Heron nods toward the limping mule below. He looks down to it. As if waiting for that cue, the mule brays out a greeting.

He looks back to Paper Heron, pinned yet completely serene. He snorts, sheaths his blade, and jumps down from the roof.

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. There's no time to waste.

In a quiet corner of the street, Mayfly stands on her tiptoes, peering around.

Paper Heron: Hey, Mayfly.

Finding no one, she darts forward still on her tiptoes.

Mayfly: Are you alright? I played a trick at the gate to distract him.

Paper Heron: Much appreciated.

Paper Heron: *blow*

Mayfly: Wow! You blew those off like dust.

Paper Heron: It's not as hard as you imagine.

Paper Heron stretches while Mayfly watches the leaf blades fall in a clatter. A hint of envy shines in her eyes.

Mayfly: I knew you'd work things out. Your mastery of arcanum is truly amazing, even if you lose your way sometimes.

Mayfly: I wish I could be like you.

Mayfly: Wandering the world, fighting and casting spells, saving my friends from danger ...

Paper Heron: Nonsense! You just saved me from the clutches of the constables, didn't you? Our lives shine equally bright.

Paper Heron: Ah, but I know what you mean. You want to learn some of my tricks, eh? I can teach you.

Mayfly: *sigh* No, that's not what I mean. Besides, there isn't time.

With a shake of her head, Mayfly swallows the words. They would have been pointless.

Mayfly: Actually, Heron, I must say farewell.

Paper Heron: Farewell? Why?

Mayfly: Well, I'd planned this even before we entered town. Would've gone sooner if not for being caught.

Paper Heron: But where will you go? I thought you were seeking the Method of Longevity.

Mayfly: I'm not leaving, just off to find some other herbaceous Yao. You know, plants of a leaf, same belief.

Paper Heron: I understand.

She nods, but there's a strange tug of emotion within it.

Mayfly: *sigh* But I worry for you already. For all your wonderful abilities, you're just so careless.

Paper Heron: Don't you worry about me. I'll be fine. Haven't met any rotten folk in this town thus far.

Paper Heron: Let me see. There's you, that gullible constable, the cake seller, and the Yao from the parade. Well, I saw through their tricks. You see, I can take care of myself.

Mayfly: Heh. You make it sound like a tale for the ages.

She wants to say more, but at the sight of Paper Heron's calm composure, she stops herself.

Mayfly: Right. This is it then. Farewell.

Paper Heron: As it must be, farewell.

Giving a wave goodbye, Paper Heron turns back with a whistle, and her mule trots behind her.

In the sunset, their shadows stretch long and thin. Paper Heron stops on the road, takes some paper and a brush from her mule's pack. Before long, a slip of paper drifts into the wind behind her.

Mayfly: *sigh* I can't tell if she's a fool or a genius.

Mayfly: Hmm? What's this in my pocket?

She reaches into her pocket to find an object she doesn't remember putting there.

It's the same amulet she had trampled, now restored, and beside it, a hastily written note:

Mayfly: Hold the amulet and chant, "Hide my body behind Zhēnwǔ and my soul in Tongming Palace," then pinch your left thumb and middle finger. That will deceive the Reversion Bell. No cultivation needed.

Mayfly: ...

Mayfly: W-When did she ...?

The warm orange light of sunset bathes Zhu County. Against the busy evening traffic, Paper Heron leads her mule, her back to Mayfly as she waves once again.

The Longevity Ritual

SU-08

Stage, Ancient Zhu County

Around the noisy opera stage, bright fish and dragon lanterns surge and dive amidst the crowd, as if breaching out of a living ocean.

The festival is reaching its busiest hour.

Mayfly: *sigh*

Mayfly: Where should I go now? I'm all alone.

Mayfly: So tired, so hungry. Not a wen to my name. Can't even buy myself a bun.

Mayfly: Where are they? Surely I'm not the only herbaceous Yao in town, am I?

Mayfly leans against a stone pillar at the Paifang and sits down as she looks out at the swirling crowd.

Mayfly: Well, even if you find no one, you'll manage. You're a reed, after all. You can take root anywhere, and let the earth feed you.

Mayfly: But I'd prefer food. What time is it now?

Mayfly: If I had known this would be so difficult, I'd have eaten more cakes while Heron was paying.

Mayfly: At least then I wouldn't be here listening to my stomach growl.

Mayfly: *sigh* If only I were an immortal. I'd never go hungry again. I'll bet their elixirs must taste better than any river water.

Mayfly: Hm? Why are people gathering around here?

Boy I: Mama! It's the iron flower fireworks! Can I see? Can I see?

Mayfly: Fireworks, gone in a moment.

Mayfly: But so beautiful.

Mayfly: If only my life had a moment like that, just one.

Du Liu: Yáng Wǔ, what are you smiling about?

Yang Wu: The iron flower fireworks. So beautiful!

Cheng Heguang: Dù Liù, Yáng Wǔ! Get your men into position! Keep your eyes on the stage!

Cheng Heguang: This is where the immortal will supposedly arrive to grant longevity. If something happens, I need you all at the ready!

Chéng Héguāng stands on an elevated platform, looking down over the happy fairgoers with an unmatching expression, too dark and serious against the joyful night.

Du Liu: But the opera doesn't start for a while yet. What's wrong, Chief? You're looking more serious than ever.

Yang Wu: A Daoist gave him the slip this afternoon.

Du Liu: What? Who could escape Chief Chéng's leaf blades?

Yang Wu: It was the lady who cast a spell at the gate, remember? Best keep an eye out for her.

Du Liu: Are these orders from you or Chief Chéng?

Yang Wu: You asked the question, I answered. No need to be snide.

Cheng Heguang: Enough. That Daoist possessed strange arcane skills, the likes of which I have never seen. I take the blame for her escape.

Cheng Heguang: Her arrival coinciding with this mysterious sect is no coincidence. She's scheming something. Stay sharp!

Du Liu: You ever wonder why the chief's sword is never blunt? I figure it's because he's always yelling at it.

Yang Wu: What are you talking about?

Du Liu: "Stay sharp! Stay sharp!"

Yang Wu: Pfft.

Cheng Heguang: Dù Liù!

Du Liu: Yes, Chief!

Their chief holds a stern face, but his cheeks betray him with a flush of red.

Cheng Heguang: I wasn't talking to my sword.

Du Liu: Right, of course, Chief!

Yang Wu: Tsk tsk, can't believe you're spreading rumors like that.

Yang Wu: I'd say that warrants a caning. Allow me to carry out the sentence.

Their chief grits his teeth, places a hand on his blade, and turns his back.

Cheng Heguang: The opera will begin soon. I need everyone in position. No more jokes. If any suspect gets away, you'll face more than a caning.

Du Liu & Yang Wu: Understood!

Cheng Heguang: Follow me, and keep your eyes and ears peeled! We must safeguard the civilians and apprehend any offenders!

Constables: Yes, Chief!

Night falls. Lanterns dot the river. More black-awning boats appear, each one festooned with candles.

Boy I: Mama, look! There's a little man dancing on the candle.

Ancient Woman I: Don't be silly. That's just the candlelight flickering.

Vendor II: Come and play pitch-pot! Young lady, dare to try your luck?

Mayfly: I ...

Yang Wu: Make way! Make way!

Yang Wu: Make way, please! We need to clear a path for the audience.

Vendor II: Of course, officer.

Mayfly: Is the opera about to begin?

Yang Wu: Yes, in just a few minutes.

Laughter and chatter close in as a group of men and women pass Yáng Wǔ.

Mayfly: Those are the Yao I met at the cake stall.

Hare: Come join us!

A parade of joyful Yao passes before Mayfly. They spin around until they seem like a carousel with her in the center, a parade with no beginning and no end.

Mayfly: I ...

Entranced by the sight, the procession sweeps Mayfly off her feet, carrying her away as if caught in the current of a flooding river.

Mayfly: Ugh!

Yang Wu: Hey! No pushing! Over there! Keep the peace, or we'll keep it for you!

Mayfly: Ugh! Eh ...

Mayfly looks back. She's been carried far only to be left in a strange place, sticking out like driftwood after a receding tide.

Mayfly: The-The stage? How did I—?

The music rises fast and loud. An opera singer steps onto the stage with quick steps.

The singer's melodious voice captures the crowd in a sudden rapture.

Mayfly: This is *Legends of Handan*!

The singing reaches the far end of the stage, where Chéng Héguāng and his men stand eyeing the proceedings suspiciously.

Cheng Heguang: *Legends of Handan*? How could they choose this of all operas with these rumors going around?

Du Liu: What's it about, Chief?

Chéng's hard stare conveys his disdain even before his words confirm it.

Cheng Heguang: It tells the story of a scholar who was guided into a dream by the immortal Lǚ Dòngbīn. There, he experienced life as an official in the imperial system; he found enlightenment once he awoke and became Lǚ's apprentice to pursue longevity.

Du Liu: Hah. No wonder you're so shook up over it.

Mayfly: I, eugh, I can't see.

Mayfly stands on her tiptoes, unable to see the stage over the crowd. But though she can't make out the scene, the song, at least, breaks through.

Mayfly: I must've watched this opera a hundred times.

Mayfly: But I've never seen them use candles before. Did they change the story?

She finds her way to the front of the stage and looks up, captivated at the performance. It pulls the joy and hope of the crowd up like spun silk that gives warmth and color to the night sky.

Countless candles ring the stage. Their flickering flames throw dim, dancing shadows on the walls, shadows that seem to sway and bob like a procession of monks in prayer.

Mayfly: It's so warm.

Fox: Goodness, how beautiful!

Hare: I can't keep myself from staring.

The flames leap out from their wax altars, speaking in a divine and wordless tongue to the people below.

Mayfly: Hold on. When did they light these candles?

Mayfly: The flames, they're whispering something.

The small lights sway beneath the night sky, alternating between bright and dim. They become a hypnotic flow that those watching cannot turn away from.

The flickering lights seem to laugh, to scold, and then to chant unclear words, venting the pain of their brief lives through the ages.

Mayfly: Yes, I can hear them. They're saying ...

Fox: Grant us longevity.

Hare: Grant us longevity.

Mayfly: Wait. When did I get this close?

A hush falls over the crowd. Mayfly looks up at the figure on the stage.

The warm light shimmers. Hearts beat in time with the swaying shadows. This stage feels as if it were instead a refuge, a bastion of light and song calling out to those who might approach it.

Under the cover of night, under the gaze of many hundreds of eyes, a hundredfold stages rise.

Cheng Heguang: Dù Liù! Yáng Wǔ! Where are you?

Cheng Heguang: Ah. They're using the candlelight to conjure illusions! Avert your eyes!

Mayfly: Only a fool would give up such a chance.

Paper Heron: Do you wish to become immortal?

Mayfly: Hmm?

Mayfly: He-Heron?

Paper Heron: Heaven and earth bear the essence which forms all life. I shall live as long as the sun and the moon shine.

The End ...?

SU-09

The candlelight fades and is soon replaced by the steady glow of modern incandescent bulbs.

Reed touches her head unconsciously, feeling blades of grass brush against her fingertips.

Reed: So, Mayfly was given the Method of Longevity. Just like she wanted.

Reed: And that means that Paper Heron was the legendary immortal.

As if a reminder, another blade of grass tumbles down at her touch.

Reed: Hmm ...

Reed: Well, true or not, I better get this down before I forget any details.

She tucks the grass into her pocket and practically leaps toward her paper and pen.

Reed: "The distinctive melodies of Eastern opera, combined with the magical glow of candlelight, brought the atmosphere to its peak. When the immortal moved her fingers, the audience, including those who had doubts about longevity ..."

Reed: "... naturally came to believe in this miracle, including Mayfly, a herbaceous Yao whose life was about to end only a few months later."

Reed: "Based on accounts from local residents and my own experience, I feel I can make a bold assumption."

Reed: "After the opera was over, Paper Heron, the legendary immortal, taught the Method of Longevity to Mayfly to extend her life. Then, for some reason, she fell into a deep sleep beneath Zhu County."

The passage of time goes unnoticed as her pen glides from page to page. The sound of scribbling accompanied first by the silence of night, then gentle birdsong, and finally the bustle of a waking city.

Reed: *stretch* Another day.

One more square in her calendar is crossed out.

Usually, she would leave a detailed journal of her day, a record for her next iteration. But today, she lets her pen rest.

Reed: Maybe I won't need to leave a note for the next "me" this time.

As the morning progresses, the storekeeper pulls up the shop's rolling shutters.

Waiting outside, aside from the morning breeze, is a familiar face.

Storekeeper: You're up early today. Did you get enough sleep?

Storekeeper: Oh, and I was so busy last night, I forgot to give you your change. Hold on. Let me unlock the door first.

Before she can even finish her words, Reed has returned to her glowing screen.

Reed: Sleep, shmeep, my article's almost finished. All I really need is a computer.

Reed: Oh. Sorry, I got a little overexcited. I meant, would it be possible to use one?

Storekeeper: I can see that, haha. Go ahead. You can use that one. You know how to turn it on.

Reed takes a deep breath before typing the words she spent the night planning.

The odd pace of the typing draws the storekeeper's attention.

Storekeeper: Are you trying to put a hole in my mouse, or is the network down?

Reed: Huh?

Reed: Oh, no, the network's fine.

It's only then that she notices that her whole arm has gone numb from the speed of her typing.

Reed: Has anyone else come by recently?

Storekeeper: No, you're the only one. But I'll keep a spot open for you. Don't you worry.

Reed: Oh, thank you!

The frantic typing resumes as soon as their conversation ends.

Central Park, Zhu County

In the daylight, Reed returns to reassess the leafy central park and the bustling construction site nearby.

The words "Immortal Residence" decorating the impressive billboard gleam down at her in the sunlight.

Far beneath it, the half-dead Mei tree that lies in the middle of the park looks dull by comparison.

Property Developer: Another journalist? I already told the other ones we're not open for interviews.

It seems she's spent too much time staring as a middle-aged man approaches in a huff.

Property Developer: I don't care who you write for. Get out of here, will you?

Reed: Oh! No, no, I'm not here for interviews. I'm just having a look around.

Reed: So, someone came around here then? Someone who looked like me?

Property Developer: I'm not answering any questions! My building isn't haunted, and that's that!

Reed: Not haunted? You mean ...

Before Reed can ask anything more, a new voice draws away their attention.

Employee: Sir! We've got a problem!

A young man, breathless from running, cuts her questioning short.

Property Developer: What, and you want to hand it over to me?

Employee: It-It's Professor Zhāng. He said he—

The property developer pulls his arm, gives a polite nod to Reed, and walks aside.

Half a minute later, Reed hears shouting.

Property Developer: Would you listen to yourself? What do you mean they were eaten by monsters?

Employee: Professor Zhāng said he found this in an ancient book. Should we just ignore him?

Property Developer: Damn him and his book! I go and call it the "Immortal Residence," and then it turns out people died here? If this gets out, I'll never sell the place!

The developer's voice rises, and Reed catches pieces of their argument on the wind.

Employee: He gave us a copy of the book. Said he'd send one to the press unless he receives 100,000 yuan today. Do you want to look at it?

Property Developer: F**k him!

While they argue, Reed slips away toward the entrance of the park.

Full of hope, she looks up at the Mei tree. Its dry branches hold many buds.

Under the tree, a mule chews on fresh green grass.

Reed: ...?

Reed: OneWithFlow?

She calls out to the mule, not entirely convinced by her own conclusion.

Mule: Whinny.

The mule, startled, turns to flee. Reed immediately takes notice of the familiar pack, one she knows she's seen before.

Reed: You traveled with Paper Heron wherever she went!

Reed: Wait.

A strong wind blows. The rustling leaves drown out the mule's trotting hooves.

A pale page falls a half step before her.

Reed: At the time, the sun and moon hung together in the sky. The earth split in two at the gate of the School of Mei, opening a rift miles long that swallowed souls.

Reed: When the governor had it investigated, they couldn't find a single human dead or alive, only clothes, dead plants, and animals.

Reed: Many believed the phenomenon was caused by the earth dragon?

Reed: ...!!!

It's not just the records that surprise her.

Where the page fell, the wind spins in midair, leading her to a precise spot.

Another Wind Knot.

Reed: Only clothes, dead plants, and animals ... The earth dragon ...

Reed: No way. Then the Yao didn't really become immortal?

To "Heaven"

SU-10

On stage, footsteps move with a light, quick pace.

Do you wish to become immortal?

Mayfly looks up but sees nothing before her.

Do you wish to become immortal?

Mayfly: Only a fool would give up such a chance.

Mayfly: Hm? Where am I?

Mayfly sits up from a comfy bed and looks around.

Mayfly: Eh!

Mayfly: This place is so luxurious.

She jumps to the floor and walks around the room, curious about her new surroundings.

Mayfly: The bed's soft, and this blanket's so light and warm.

Mayfly: What a strange dream I had, but, my, do I feel rested?

Mayfly: *deep breath* I'm brimming with energy! I haven't felt this good since autumn. With strength like this flowing through me—

Mayfly: I could till a whole field all on my own!

Mayfly: That vase is almost as big as me, but I bet I could lift it.

She finds herself standing in front of the vase in the corner, excitedly stretching out her hands to measure its height and width.

???: Hello, Mayfly.

Mayfly: Who-Who's that? Wait.

Mayfly: Paper Heron?

???: We were chatting outside your room when we heard your voice. I'm glad to see that you are doing well.

???: I know what you wish to ask. You are in the School of Mei.

The lady smiles and nods as she explains further.

???: And I am its founder. They call me Master Rén, or Rén the Immortal.

Mayfly: Rén the Immortal.

Mayfly: Th-Then, you must be the immortal everyone's been talking about?

Mayfly: Please, Master, teach me the Method of Longevity!

Master Ren: Hah hah. Another young soul looking too far ahead to see the truth before them.

Master Ren: The immortal you seek is standing right in front of you, but it isn't me. In fact, I was one of her students.

Mayfly: What?

Mayfly shifts her focus between Master Rén and Paper Heron before resting on the more comfortably familiar face.

Saying nothing, Master Rén smiles and follows Mayfly's gaze to Paper Heron.

Mayfly: Heron? You mean, she's the immortal?!

Paper Heron stirs the sweet soup in her bowl. The white sugar has sunk to the bottom.

Paper Heron: I'd prefer if you wouldn't call me that, Mayfly. Makes me feel as though I'm covered in ants.

Mayfly: But how can that be?

Master Ren: Do you recall the evening passed?

Mayfly: Last night, I was pushed out on the stage, and then ...

Master Ren: Precisely. It was then that Paper Heron held the longevity ritual for you. You fell into a deep slumber for the rest of the night.

Master Ren: How do you feel now?

Mayfly: I feel refreshed, energetic, alive. Then, I've gained longevity already?

Master Ren: No. This is but the first step.

Master Ren: Master Heron altered the flowing pattern of your Qi to imitate that of the Way, laying the foundation for true longevity cultivation.

Master Ren: But this alone will not extend your life. To achieve true longevity, one must cultivate it through the method of our school. Worry not. I will be your guide.

Mayfly: I see. No, wait.

Mayfly looks puzzled; she counts her fingers, as if attempting to follow the logic to its conclusion.

Mayfly: Paper Heron, if you're Master Rén's master and the founder of the School of Mei ...

Mayfly: Then you knew all along? You were just pretending?

Mayfly: Th-Then, you lied too! You know, I felt so guilty about leaving you behind!

Paper Heron: I didn't deceive you. I had no inkling that it was Rén that you sought.

Paper Heron: I only learned of her ritual on the stage at the last instant. I took her place as its officiator as a bit of fun.

Paper Heron: But I looked quite splendid up there, don't you think? Didn't you notice it was me?

At this pleasant thought, Paper Heron spoons some of the sweet soup into her mouth.

Mayfly: ...

Mayfly: So it was you who slipped the amulet and the note into my pocket.

Paper Heron: Of course. I hadn't cast that spell for some time, so I thought I'd seize the opportunity to give it a spin.

Paper Heron: Ah, why the glum look, eh? Our performance was a great success. Yao have joined the school in spadefuls.

Mayfly: They're here for the Method, not your magic tricks.

Mayfly: Ah, scythe me down. You're the immortal! How could I say such a thing?

Before Mayfly can finish, hurried steps outside cut her off.

Mayfly: Hm?

The footsteps stop at the door, followed by whispers and the rustle of clothes.

Suddenly, a short, plump hedgehog and a yam with a leafy head peek out from behind the door. Then a gray rat, a shrew, and behind them, a whole parade of other Yao.

Noisy Yao: Immortal! Please, forgive our intrusion. We're here to see you and our new schoolmate.

Shy Yao: Grandmaster, our greatest thanks for these artifacts. We've brought a token of our gratitude. Though it's not so valuable, I hope it will suffice.

Paper Heron: Oh, think nothing of it. Consider it a gift from your grandmaster.

Noisy Yao: Thank you, Immor—Uh, Grandmaster. Erm, if it's not too much trouble, could you teach us the spell you used on the stage last night?

Mayfly: ...

Paper Heron waves their praise away with her hand, but the smile behind that waving hand reveals her joy.

Paper Heron: Sure, it's not so difficult. Just say what more you want to learn, and I shall teach you.

The Yao pour in, talking excitedly with Paper Heron. Mayfly watches as her friend-turned-grandmaster enters the circle and shakes her head.

Master Ren: Ahem!

A few clear coughs cut the clamoring voices short.

Master Ren: Now, now, students. You ought to show respect in the presence of the grandmaster. Enough playfulness. You must all return to your cultivation.

Shy Yao: But I hear this is the first time the grandmaster has visited our school in many years. We only wanna talk to her.

Paper Heron: And talk we shall.

Master Rén smiles.

Master Ren: The grandmaster will be with us for many days. There will be plenty of time.

Master Ren: For now, we ought to consider our newest schoolmate. You need some time to settle in, isn't that so, Mayfly?

Mayfly: Err ...

Master Ren: You have just received the ritual. Your body needs time to adapt.

Master Ren: Students, will you show Mayfly around our school? A little bit of activity should do her good.

Paper Heron: Ah, right. Best to get some exercise.

Noisy Yao: Whatever you say, Master.

Noisy Yao: Mayfly, is it? We brought you a gift too. Sorry, we got carried away after seeing the grandmaster.

The Yao bring out several boxes of herbs and steamers filled with cakes, all prepared in advance—a substantial offering.

Mayfly: That's alright, and thank you for the gift. I feel so full of energy now. I'd love to look around.

Paper Heron: You should spend some time getting to know the other students. Your gift can wait.

Mayfly: Alright then. I can save it for later.

Mayfly pats her skirt and leaves with the Yao. Soon, she enters a busy courtyard bustling with the voices of other students of the School of Mei.

Noisy Yao: Stop it, Mayfly! That cauldron's too heavy! You could hurt yourself.

Master Ren: Heh heh. I was just like her back then. Didn't know what to do with my newfound strength.

Paper Heron lifts another spoonful of her sweet soup to her lips and then sets the bowl down.

Master Ren: So, have you retrieved your five senses?

Paper Heron: Hmm. Mmm.

Master Rén nods and waits for Paper Heron to swallow.

Paper Heron: No, it's become worse. Even clear soup is practically tasteless to me now. But enough about that; we have more important things to discuss.

Paper Heron: My divinations suggest that Lǎnzhū is waking. I have observed many omens along the road.

Paper Heron: Birds migrating north, withered grass blackening. Ere long, Lǎnzhū will awaken.

Paper Heron: Unlike other Xiǎndào Beasts, Lǎnzhū is not under Zhènzǐ's control. The quake it wrought brought great suffering to the Huanzhou region.

Paper Heron: The White Horse School once fought it, and I among them, yet we could only force it into a long slumber.

Paper Heron: Until the Way bestowed on us two Swords of Longevity, allowing ordinary students to control the Qi of Yin and Yang in order to pacify Lǎnzhū.

Paper Heron: But then ...

She pauses.

Master Ren: You need not say more.

Master Rén draws an array in the air. It glows gold for a moment, then fades as a white sword appears.

Paper Heron stares intently at the sword. It floats in the air, radiating with a soft white glow.

Paper Heron: Now, only one sword remains.

Paper Heron: And the White Horse School is no more.

Her hands shake as she grips it, as if she were holding it too tightly.

Master Ren: You needn't worry. Since the moment you passed the sword to me, I have been making preparations to face Lǎnzhū.

Master Ren: I know the consequences if I fail. The earth will split, and beneath the dual sun and moon, disaster and disorder will reign.

Master Ren: Zhu County, all of Huanzhou, will shatter, causing untold devastation.

Master Ren: That is why I founded the School of Mei to gather strength in numbers.

Master Ren: Though I wield the last Sword of Longevity, if it should fail, I have prepared a Quelling Array. But I will need their strength to help me activate it.

Paper Heron: Oh!

Master Ren: Do I surprise you?

Paper Heron looks around the room and answers with a sigh.

Paper Heron: Ah, no. It's just ... You were but a little Yao when we first met beneath that tree. Look how you've grown.

Master Ren: Heh heh. A Yao's life is shorter than most. We must make every day count.

Master Ren: You entrusted this task to me, and I will do all that I must to finish it.

Master Ren: I will allow nothing to get in my way. Not only for the sake of the school, but for the sake of everyone in this land.

She sees Rén's smile. Paper Heron pauses, then offers an affirming smile to her old student.

Paper Heron: You are more prepared than I could ever hope to be. But mind your students well. I should not like to see your school meet the same fate as mine, eh?

Paper Heron: I will stay here until the task is done. And intervene if need be.

Master Rén replies with a solemn nod.

Master Ren: Grandmaster, you gave me a second life and the Sword of Longevity. I owe my life to you.

Master Ren: I swear I will complete the suppression, no matter the cost. For you and for your school.

Dilemma

SU-11

In the dim cell, low chants rise and fall over and over until it almost feels like a natural phenomenon, like the howling of the wind.

Constable I: Chief, all the Yao we've arrested are here.

Jail, Ancient Zhu County

A cell door creaks open slowly. The other Yao stop and look out from their cells at the three who enter.

Cheng Heguang: ...

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. This must be the true meaning of being "watched like a hawk."

Cheng Heguang: You may leave. I will have the victim identify the culprit.

Constable I: Understood.

The cell is packed with Yao. Afraid, a man presses himself fearfully against Chéng Héguāng.

Chéng grips his blade and tells the man not to be afraid, as he takes the first bold step toward them.

Cheng Heguang: I trust there's no need to introduce myself.

Bird: Of course, Chief Chéng. After all, it took us all quite some effort to sneak past you, hahahahaha.

Bird: Let no one say that you neglected your duties. In fact, you did such a sterling job that not even a fly could buzz through that gate.

Bird: A pity for you that I soar much higher than a fly! Ahahahahahaha!

The Yao all laugh, leading Chéng Héguāng to raise his blade and strike it against the cell door.

Cheng Heguang: Quiet!

Cheng Heguang: Look over them. See if you can identify the one that abducted your family.

Even with the cell door between them, the man feels surrounded by Yao; he dodges fruitlessly left then right as if to avoid their gaze.

He peeks at the jailed Yao from the corner of his eye. But each glance makes him all the more concerned.

County Resident I: I-I don't see them.

Bird: My, my, should I call you County Magistrate Chéng now? If I recall correctly, it falls outside of the duties of mere constables to interrogate suspects.

Through the bars, a bird-like Yao leans toward Chéng Héguāng.

Bird: Could it be that you are using this opportunity to learn the Method of Longevity for yourself? Haha!

Cheng Heguang: Enough of your twittering, bird. I am investigating this rumor on behalf of the people, not for myself.

Cheng Heguang: Nor is this a formal interrogation. I am within my rights to question any one of you.

Bird: Heh heh. And if I don't tell you a thing, what then, Chief Chéng?

Bird: Must you really be so harsh on us? Every Yao in Zhu County is scared to death of you.

Bird: But I know that you're not all that cruel-hearted. Could you be persuaded to let us go?

As she speaks, she puts both hands through the bars. One holds a gold bar, the other a charm. She waves them before Chéng Héguāng.

Bird: I can offer you both wealth and health.

Cheng Heguang: Fiend! I will not allow you to deceive me.

Chéng Héguāng pushes her hands aside with the back of his blade. She jumps back, staring at him tensely, then approaches once more.

Bird: You think it deception merely because you believe the Method of Longevity to be a false rumor.

Bird: But what if I tell you, it's true, hm? Take a guess at how old I am.

Cheng Heguang: There's no need to guess. It is said that Yao can live over a thousand years.

Bird: Whoever told you that knew nothing. Our lives are scarcely longer than our true forms. My own kind live and die within the age of a sparrow. Nothing more.

Surprise flashes in Chéng Héguāng's eyes. He motions for her to continue.

Bird: We only want a little more time in this world, Chief Chéng. Why must you stand in our way?

Cheng Heguang: Then should I simply allow you and your people to kill, steal, and bring chaos?

Bird: Me and my people?

She is stunned for a moment, then responds with a burst of laughter.

Bird: Hahahaha ... I see.

Bird: You believe the Yao to be evil.

Cheng Heguang: No, not universally. Yet it is Yao like you who spread these dangerous rumors in the county.

The Yao stops laughing, her neck jerking in as her feathers rise and puff out.

Filled with rage, she storms toward Chéng Héguāng, ignoring the bars.

Bird: It is no rumor, fool! Even if it were, what harm have we ever brought for speaking it alone? All our kind desire is to live!

Bird: I've done nothing wrong! Release me! Every moment is precious!

Cheng Heguang: You may not have taken part in these abductions, but the rumors you spread surely enticed the ones that did. I will not release you.

Bird: Fine, continue in your blindness, but the School of Mei will bring justice to us all.

The Yao turns fierce, beating her wings in the cell. Claw marks cover the walls.

Cheng Heguang: The School of Mei. That's the name of your sect, is it?

Her anger has become an incomprehensible mash of threats and insults. Chéng Héguāng stands between her and the scared man, leading him away.

Study, Yamen

In the Yamen's study, the man sits shaking on a wooden chair.

Cheng Heguang: Calm down. Have some tea.

County Resident I: Th-Thank you.

He takes the tea, sips a few times, then sets it down.

Cheng Heguang: No need to worry; our cells are quite unbreakable.

Cheng Heguang: So, what more do you know of the Yao that abducted your family?

County Resident I: It was jabbering on about "longevity." That's all I know.

Cheng Heguang: This rumor is a true menace to society.

County Resident I: Please, Chief Chéng, please find my father. You're my only hope.

He grabs the front of Chéng Héguāng's clothes as if to kneel. But the chief constable catches him by the arms and lifts him to his feet.

Cheng Heguang: Please, sir. I am merely fulfilling my duty.

Cheng Heguang: I will find the truth. This I swear.

County Resident I: Thank you.

Cheng Heguang: Rest a while. Best not to overwork yourself.

Cheng Heguang: Guard!

Constable I: Chief.

Cheng Heguang: Take care of the good man. I must deliver my report on the events at the opera.

Constable I: Understood.

Chéng Héguāng pats the poor man's shoulder as they walk out.

A breeze follows him past the door and scatters far away.

Hall, Yamen

In the great hall, a report on the case is being given to the gathered court.

Registrar: The female Daoist raised her sword above a woman's head, revealing the latter's true form to be that of a herbaceous entity and shifting her withered leaves into a verdant green.

Registrar: The Daoist then proclaimed the ability to bestow longevity upon any who joined her school. This declaration incited the crowd to a frenzy as they stampeded the stage.

Registrar: Later, the Daoist vanished from the scene together with the herbaceous entity. Several Yao present were detained, and the injured were escorted to the nearest clinic for treatment.

Registrar: In summary, the stampede has been determined to be an unforeseen incident arising from the female Daoist's use of arcane skills.

With the report concluded, the paper is folded once more and then handed over to the county magistrate.

County Magistrate: "Unforeseen incident"? Your lack of foresight has seen this longevity rumor spread to every corner of the county!

County Magistrate: Yao are flooding our lands in droves! Never in my life have I received so many reports of missing persons and acts of sedition!

County Magistrate: Make no mistake. This is the result of your errors!

The magistrate crumples the paper and throws it at the registrar. In response, the man bows even lower.

County Magistrate: *sigh* We were foolish to put our faith in you.

County Magistrate: Commander Lì, you are in charge of our defenses. Tell me, how should we proceed?

Lì Huìfēng had been standing nearby; he pauses, considering the details for a moment, before speaking out in a measured tone.

Li Huifeng: In these desperate times, I can see only one solution.

Li Huifeng: I would divide all constables into two shifts and have them sweep the entire county. We will locate and apprehend all Yao hiding among the populace over the next three days.

County Magistrate: Very good! Do you hear that? All departments will cooperate with Commander Lì! And if I hear of any misconduct, I will show no mercy!

The others hasten to agree as they bow with clasped hands.

Chéng Héguāng has been wanting to speak. Seeing his chance, he seizes it and steps forward.

Cheng Heguang: Honorable Magistrate, I believe we also ought to consider investigating the School of Mei.

The other clerks sneak sneering glances toward him, like a discolored bean sifted from the pile.

County Magistrate: And you are? Wait, I believe I recall, Chief Chéng, is it?

County Magistrate: And this School of Mei? A minor religious sect, yes?

Cheng Heguang: Yes. Please forgive me. After the report was submitted, I discovered a connection between the sect and the animal carcasses found on the streets.

Cheng Heguang: While in custody, a suspect admitted that the School of Mei was behind the mysterious parade connected to both the rumors and the drained carcasses.

Cheng Heguang: I believe this opera was another part of their scheme. If the Yao are the fruit, the School of Mei is the root.

The others look away and whisper.

Deputy Magistrate: And who are you to speak? Some upstart boy desperate to clear his family name?

Registrar: That's him alright. Just last month, he was ranting about some thief-catching scheme; the argument could be heard from the streets.

Deputy Magistrate: Do you remember last year? This boy nigh on knocked the doors down, insisting we include those deserters he caught in our update to the Imperial Court.

Deputy Magistrate: Hard to believe the magistrate allowed him to leave with his head. It seems he hasn't any sense for his position or his shame.

Registrar: The son of a bandit turncoat. No wonder he barks like a dog, demanding praise for his every deed.

Registrar: He's fooling himself if he thinks he can wash himself clean of his family's past.

Chéng Héguāng ignores their whispers and stands tall and firm as a noble pine.

County Magistrate: Commander Lì, thoughts on this matter?

As all else goes quiet, Lì Huìfēng clears his throat and speaks.

Li Huifeng: Ahem. I hold to what I've said before; the Yao pose a serious danger to the people. Our priority must be to expel them from the county.

Li Huifeng: What would you have us do, Your Honor?

County Magistrate: The matter is handed to Commander Lì. Dismissed.

Constables: Understood.

Cheng Heguang: But the School of Mei ...

The others seem prepared to leave, but Chéng Héguāng looks around anxiously, until finding the familiar shape of his commander waiting under the eaves.

Cheng Heguang: Commander Lì!

Li Huifeng: Come here, Héguāng.

Lì Huìfēng walks from the hall in long, quick strides, forcing his subordinate to hurry to keep pace.

Li Huifeng: Are you really so desperate for glory that you forget the chain of command?

Li Huifeng: How do you aim to win trust if you refuse to pay respect to your betters?

Cheng Heguang: I apologize, Commander.

Cheng Heguang: But this is a promising lead. If we don't act now, we may miss our chance.

Lì Huìfēng turns, his voice sterner than ever.

Li Huifeng: Do you think you're the only one with a lead on this case?

Li Huifeng: That no one else can do as you have done? Not even those with greater power and resources?

Li Huifeng: Is that why you announced your intentions for all to hear? Your heart may be pure, but others have their own designs. If your words reach the wrong ears, do you think they will sit and do nothing about it?

Chéng Héguāng's tongue twists. He had prepared for a scolding, not this.

Cheng Heguang: Commander, you mean ...

Li Huifeng: Keep digging, but do not draw any further attention.

Li Huifeng: That's all for today. And if your actions are brought to light, I will tell them I denied your request, understood?

Cheng Heguang: Yes, Commander!

He bows deeply, then straightens his posture.

Cheng Heguang: I will learn from your wise words.

Castle in the Sky

SU-12

Yard, School of Mei

Master Ren: Come, Mayfly. You ought to familiarize yourself with our school before you begin.

Mayfly: Yes, Master.

Mayfly peeks out from behind the door, watching the others in the front courtyard.

Mayfly: It's still early in the morning, but everyone's already up and busy.

Master Ren: It is. Soon, you will be practicing alongside them.

The many Yao she has come to know nod to her in greeting.

Master Ren: The students live in the side house here, as will you. I believe you've met some of them already.

Quick Mouse: *squeak*

Mayfly: I see, ah! There's a mouse climbing up on that bamboo by the wall.

Master Ren: Heh. Don't be alarmed by Brother Mouse. He has taken to staying in his true form most of the day.

Mayfly: F-Forgive me, Brother.

Master Ren: I'm sure he does not mind. The School of Mei is one of the few refuges for Yao in this region. Our students are free to live in whatever form they wish. You may even choose to live as a reed, if that is what you desire.

Mayfly: Live in my true form. But I ...

Master Ren: One must learn to find fulfillment in their true nature; only then may one discern their path to the Way. It will make sense in time.

Mayfly: Hmm.

Master Ren: Come. Let us speak further in the front courtyard.

Mayfly: Master, where is that music coming from? I keep hearing it, but I don't see anyone playing.

Master Ren: You won't have need of that haste much longer, Sister Mayfly.

Master Ren: This is the front courtyard, where students may gather to train or rest as they like.

Mayfly: But no one's here.

Master Ren: This way.

The gardens of this land excel at artful concealment. Past the moon gate, after a few winding paths, a hidden world opens up to her.

Black eaves press down upon white rooms that enclose a square. The ground is paved with gravel, into which white marble tiles are set, forming a Bagua array.

Students in white stand atop it, playing solemn Daoist music together.

Yam: There she is, the new student!

Hedgehog: Sister Mayfly, are you feeling better?

Paper Heron waits here too. The students occasionally steal small glances at her.

She looks around, nodding to the students as she meets their eyes and greeting Mayfly in particular.

Mayfly: Hello, everyone, what are you all doing here?

All Yao: Master Rén is here too!

All Yao: Greetings, Master! We humbly request your guidance this day!

Master Ren: It's good to see you all. Please, be seated.

The crowd spreads out and sits in a ring around Master Rén. A female Yao pulls Mayfly in to sit beside her.

Master Ren: Revision always offers new insight. And with a new student among us today, let us begin by reviewing the stages of the Method of Longevity.

Master Ren: To master this art, one must attain three stages: the regulation of Qi, concentration and visualization, and the cultivation of the body.

Master Ren: In the first stage, we focus on the rhythm of the breath. Each of you must find the pace which best suits your constitution and nature.

Master Ren: Once you reach a state of meditation, we will work to concentrate the mind on an object, opening ourselves to the stimuli of the divine, as for the cultivation of the body.

Hearing this, Paper Heron interrupts Master Rén.

Paper Heron: That wouldn't be for the best.

Master Ren: Whatever do you mean, Master?

Paper Heron: Your students are getting ahead of themselves. Teach them the basics first, eh? A pavilion is not built from the roof down.

Master Ren: If I am to cover every foundational detail, I would have to start from before the White Horse School was even founded.

Master Ren: Unfortunately, I never walked its halls. All that I know, I learned from you. Would you do us the honor, Grandmaster?

Master Ren: The students would be most grateful to hear it from your lips.

Paper Heron looks around. The students wait eagerly for her words. The School of Mei seems to be thriving on the high morale of its students, and her heart is warmed by it.

Paper Heron: It has been quite some time since I last spoke of my old school, but I'd be happy to.

She lifts her heels and leaps gracefully into the ring before launching into her story.

Paper Heron: The very first attempts at achieving longevity can be traced back to ancient times, but it's enough to start with the founding of the White Horse School, eh?

Paper Heron: It first took shape in the late Tang Dynasty, as our founding master traveled the land collecting many rare and lost scriptures in hopes of preserving the Daoist arts for future generations.

Paper Heron: From those arts, he developed a method to balance Yin and Yang, and through it, discovered the secret to a long life.

Paper Heron: He named it The Practice of Inner Alchemy, and it later became the foundation of the White Horse School.

Paper Heron: Now, to perform it properly, you must work through these stages in order. Listen closely.

Paper Heron: The scripture says, "When one's mind is tranquil and free of distracting thoughts, all things between heaven and earth will become one with it." So, the first step is to set aside worldly concerns and seek stillness from within, for only then can one perceive the presence of the Way.

Paper Heron: Step two is about finding your Qi. "Life is born of the accumulation of Qi. When Qi gathers, we live; when it disperses, we perish."

Paper Heron: Without Qi, we can neither strengthen our bodies nor nourish our spirits, and so we cannot prolong our lives. We must spend years learning its workings, until it becomes as familiar to us as our own hands.

Paper Heron: The third step is to use your understanding of Qi to work its flow, guiding it until it moves in harmony with the Way.

Paper Heron: This step is the most crucial—when your body attunes itself to your Qi and allows you to retain it. This may take some time, but it must not be rushed.

Paper Heron: "Without the Qi within, the body stands hollow. And if hollow, how may life endure in it?"

Paper Heron: This takes real devotion. You must practice daily until your body is ready to harmonize with the flow of Qi.

Paper Heron: "To retain Qi is to attain the Way; one who has attained the Way may long endure," so the scripture says.

Paper Heron: But the path is long and perilous. Stray from it, and both body and spirit may be annihilated.

Paper Heron: At best, it is a process of decades; at worst, well, I've seen some wait hundreds of years.

Hedgehog: But, Grandmaster ...

Paper Heron: Yes? Speak your mind.

Hedgehog: Do you really mean it will take a few decades for us to master this method?

Paper Heron: To walk the path of longevity is no small feat. But the calmer your mind, the clearer your vision, and the quicker you will progress.

Hedgehog: But how can I devote myself to a method that takes decades to master when I only have a few years to live? And if what you say is true, wouldn't only the long-lived be able to achieve longevity?

Paper Heron: Ah!

She pauses, composing her thoughts for a long while, then walks over to the Gen trigram.

Paper Heron: Not entirely. The scripture says, "In the pursuit of worldly knowledge, one gains daily. In the pursuit of the Way, one loses daily. Less and less is done, until nothing is done. When nothing is done, nothing is left undone."

Paper Heron: Don't get so hung up on the path ahead. Nothing stays fixed forever. Live in the moment, and new opportunities will arise.

Hedgehog: So we'll just do nothing at all?

Paper Heron: Not exactly. It isn't nothing but rather "non-action." We let go of all deliberate effort, attending to your purposes, doing only that which is yours to do.

Hearing her words, the Yao look at each other. One of them cannot hold back their frustration and rushes up in front of her.

Badger: That's absurd!

Badger: If that's how it is, what are we to do? Sit around and wait for death to come? Our lives are much shorter than yours, you know!

Yam: Now, now, Brother Badger. The grandmaster didn't mean ...

Undeterred by the gentle redirection, the Yao continues his questions anyway.

Badger: "That which is yours to do." What's that supposed to mean? Is this "what's mine to do"?

Hedgehog: Grandmaster, none of us would be here if we had been content with the time we were given.

Paper Heron: Ah ...

Paper Heron is speechless. She sees now the crux of the issue; they have been led astray from the very beginning.

The doubting voices grow louder. The Yao become agitated. Paper Heron stands silent above them, lost. Mayfly struggles in her seat, not knowing who to agree with.

Master Ren: Alright, everyone.

A clear, loud call rings out like a stone dropped in water. The Yao immediately fall silent.

Badger: Master.

Master Rén walks into the ring and stands beside her teacher.

Master Ren: Each of us approaches the Way differently, for we are all guided by our own nature. The grandmaster speaks only from her own experience.

Master Ren: If her words help you, hold them. If they muddle you, do not be troubled. You may understand them in the time to come.

Yam: Yes, Master.

Master Ren: It's been a long day, and the grandmaster has traveled far. Please, leave her to rest.

Paper Heron looks at her former student and then at the calmed Yao. With a stiff nod, she resigns herself to a stone stool outside the ring.

Mayfly: Heron, are you alright?

She walks over and sits by Paper Heron, whose serene facade now seems ever so subtly broken.

Paper Heron: I'm fine. Should've chosen my words with more care, though.

Mayfly: Well ...

For a moment, the cicada chirps and bird calls sound unusually sharp.

Paper Heron looks down, hiding her face.

Paper Heron: I thought they'd be interested. Back in my time ...

The words are a faint whisper, so light she barely hears them.

Mayfly: What do you mean?

Paper Heron: Nothing. Just forget what I've said and follow your master's teachings.

Paper Heron: Perhaps she's found a better way.

Master Ren: The third step the grandmaster spoke of is what we call the "cultivation of the body." Through practice, your body will work with your Qi until they are one.

Master Ren: Mastering this may take decades, even hundreds of years, but here in the School of Mei, we needn't dwell on that step. Instead, we focus on the regulation of Qi, and concentration and visualization.

Paper Heron: ...

She looks over to Master Rén as she continues her lesson and resolves herself to what must be done.

Paper Heron: "We needn't dwell on that step"?

Unbending Will

SU-13

Constable II: Move! Constables on duty. Make way!

The sun sets in the west. Meanwhile, constables armed with bows and blades march through the streets.

Like a long, cobalt dragon, they pass by as people watch curiously and whisper to each other, wondering at their destination.

Two constables hurry to reach the young man leading the grim-faced parade.

Yang Wu: Chief, there's no trace of that reed girl anywhere. She's disappeared.

Cheng Heguang: I see. Stay sharp and keep an eye out for her. We can't allow any more Yao to escape.

Du Liu: News from the west gate: two more Yao have been captured. Do you want to question them yourself like last time?

Cheng Heguang: I'll be there shortly.

Yang Wu: We've been walking for a while now. Where are you leading us?

Yáng Wǔ still wants to speak, but their chief raises his right hand, signaling the marching constables behind to stop.

Cheng Heguang: This is it!

The house before them lies at the street's end. Its doors are tightly shut, but chanting voices escape out through the cracks.

???: Withered grass devours bone. On icy plain the spirits moan. When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.

???: All returns to origin. Longevity draws near. Stars will shift only when the true path appears. Depart from this strange world, and find peace in the immortal realm.

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. The source was right. Yao are gathering here.

Chéng Héguāng clenches his fist toward the door, then lifts it in a sharp upward motion.

The metal bolt falls with a clang.

Cheng Heguang: Move in!

He draws his blade and throws the door open. The constables pour into the small square courtyard, ringing their Reversion Bells.

Cheng Heguang: Patrol constables! Civilians, stay back!

Prominent Local Merchant I: By whose order are you here? Who gave you the right?

Cheng Heguang: Hmph, quite the posture for a wanted suspect.

Cheng Heguang: You're all under arrest. Seize them!

Prominent Local Merchant II: This is outrageous! You jumped-up toll collector! How dare you lay your hands on us!

Prominent Local Merchant II: Urgh! What on earth is that noise?

Prominent Local Merchant I: That's enough! I said enough! Stop!

The bells ring under the eaves. Those inside cover their ears, but no tails grow, and no bark forms to cover their skin.

Cheng Heguang: They're not Yao?

The young chief constable is struck still, grappling with the unexpected outcome. These people dressed in fine silks are wealthy merchants, not Yao cultists.

From outside, older, wiser constables peek in, while the newer, oblivious recruits continue to ring their bells as ordered.

Cheng Heguang: Stop the bells!

The constables stop, and Chéng Héguāng looks over the crowd before sheathing his blade.

Cheng Heguang: I am Chief Constable Chéng, acting under orders to investigate the Yao involved in the Stilted Parade. I have been instructed to bring them to justice without delay.

Cheng Heguang: The verses you were reciting are identical to those the Yao chanted at the parade. If I am mistaken, I humbly ask for your forgiveness in advance.

Prominent Local Merchant II: Can you believe this petulant boy? He thought we were Yao gathering for some evil ritual!

Prominent Local Merchant II: Watch yourself, "Chief Constable." Slandering a respected merchant like myself could get you in serious trouble!

Cheng Heguang: All are equal before the law. I only act in accordance with it. I ask your presence at the Yamen, so please, gentlemen, come with us.

Cheng Heguang: Should you be proven innocent, I will offer my deepest apologies.

Prominent Local Merchant III: Do you know who you're speaking to, boy?

Prominent Local Merchant III: I won't leave this house unless your superior comes and explains everything in person!

Cheng Heguang: I ...

The air feels heavy as lead. The constables look at each other, no one daring to speak.

For a moment, the standstill feels as if it might go on forever, until the tension is at last cut by a voice from outside.

Li Huifeng: Gentlemen, I'm afraid there's been a misunderstanding.

Cheng Heguang: Sir?

The constables part respectfully as Lì Huìfēng marches into the courtyard, followed by a plump middle-aged man in brocade.

Li Huifeng: Those honorable gentlemen are simply studying the classics and cultivating their minds.

Li Huifeng: It has nothing to do with the turmoil on the streets, nor with the Yao's evil deeds.

Prominent Local Merchant IV: You speak the truth, Commander. These classics the gentlemen were reciting are scriptures transcribed by His Eminence Zhāng himself! They serve only to enlighten the mind.

Prominent Local Merchant IV: But no doubt our young Chief Constable here only intended to perform his duties and perhaps leaped to judgment. Is that so, Commander?

Li Huifeng: I thank you for your understanding and your timely message, else this could have been an even greater humiliation. Héguāng, apologize to the honorable gentlemen.

Chéng Héguāng remains silent and stares at the scripture scroll in the man's hand.

Li Huifeng: Chéng Héguāng! Do you not hear me?

Cheng Heguang: I acted thoughtlessly. For that I am sorry, Your Excellencies.

Li Huifeng: Do you think that an acceptable apology? When we return to the Yamen, you'll suffer sixty strokes for your insolence!

Prominent Local Merchant IV: Please, no need to be so harsh, Commander. I'm certain the chief acted with the best intentions. Young men often rush to judgment. We've all done the same.

Speaking back and forth, Lì Huìfēng and the middle-aged merchant ease the tension at last.

A look passes among those in the courtyard. The obvious leader among them speaks.

Prominent Local Merchant I: No real harm has been done to us; do not punish him for doing his duty.

Prominent Local Merchant II: Just be sure to keep your officers in line, Lì!

Li Huifeng: Of course. Your generosity is greatly appreciated, gentlemen. We shall take our leave.

Lì Huìfēng says no more and signals for the constables to leave the courtyard.

A wounded cobalt dragon retreats back to its cave in the form of a slow and dreary procession of downcast faces.

Lì Huìfēng stands ahead, unconcerned with the sour faces of the lower ranks behind him.

Cheng Heguang: ...

With their commander present, the constables dare not even speak as they pass through the doors of the Yamen and file away to the mess hall.

Only Chéng Héguāng remains by the entrance, struggling to hold his head high. The result is something stiff and strange but proud.

Li Huifeng: Why are you standing there like a statue? It's time to eat.

Cheng Heguang: I'm awaiting my sixty strokes.

Lì Huìfēng puts down the case file and looks at him with a complex expression.

Li Huifeng: *sigh* There won't be any coming. Now, go eat.

But he still does not move.

Cheng Heguang: If you've elected to spare me, then allow me a question, Commander.

Cheng Heguang: The man who came with you had a scroll in his hand. Where did it come from? There's a Bagua array on it, formed by a Mei tree and a jade sword.

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, if I spare you the punishment, you ought to at least do me the courtesy of sparing me the questions.

Cheng Heguang: Then I would rather take the punishment.

The evening wind blows through the hall, and the candlelight flickers in response.

Li Huifeng: Do you really have no inkling of who you offended tonight?

Cheng Heguang: I do not.

Li Huifeng: The Chén family, respected gentry with three Imperial Scholars in only a few decades. Lord Lù, a corps leader, his family have served in the military for generations. And the Lǐs—I needn't remind you who they are.

Cheng Heguang: I am but the son of bandits. I don't know any of these high lords.

Li Huifeng: Now you know.

Lì Huìfēng looks away and reads from the case file.

Cheng Heguang: The man with the scroll—is he of noble birth, too?

He does not receive an answer.

Cheng Heguang: Am I right to assume that you've kept me from investigating the School of Mei, not because you feared I might alarm them, but because you are aware of the school's prestigious background?

The words are pointed but do not break his commander's grim silence.

Cheng Heguang: You know they're responsible for the turmoil in the county, yet you permit these men to walk free, allowing the common Yao to take the fall—

Li Huifeng: Enough!

Lì Huìfēng rises with an expression as fiery as a lit rocket as he throws the files to the ground.

Li Huifeng: Are you so naive? Do you truly have no clue as to why you were spared today?

Cheng Heguang: Because of your connection to the man with the scroll.

Li Huifeng: Then you do have some inkling of what's going on!

Li Huifeng: You did well capturing those Yao, and I had planned to speak highly of you before Lord Lù. But after your actions today—storming into a civilian's home, attempting to arrest all present—how can I possibly recommend you!?

Li Huifeng: Have you forsaken your vow and decided to live in your father's disgrace forever?

Cheng Heguang: I would never!

He grits his teeth but does not give an inch.

Cheng Heguang: But Commander, this is more important than my name. This is for the safety of the townspeople!

Li Huifeng: Alright. Then tell me exactly what harm the School of Mei has done and what crime you accuse them of.

Cheng Heguang: As my prior report states, they are practicing sorcery and other forbidden arts.

Li Huifeng: They fabricated the descent of a deity at the parade, yes. But have you caught any of the offenders from that day?

Cheng Heguang: Not yet.

Li Huifeng: And has any member of the school actually committed a crime? Or have you found some scripture that proves their evil intention?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Cheng Heguang: I have not.

Li Huifeng: So you have nothing. You wish me to convince the magistrate to act against the School of Mei, risking the anger of officials and high lords based on nothing? Hm?

Li Huifeng: The school will claim that they were only teaching the methods to strengthen the body and enrich the mind, and that the Yao were foolish and greedy to think their practices could grant longevity.

Li Huifeng: We cannot act on hearsay and rumors, especially when it may anger the high lords!

Cheng Heguang: You're right. I lack the evidence to refute your words.

Cheng Heguang: But if it is the lords that worry you, I will investigate in secret. Three days is all I need. I will find the proof.

Li Huifeng: Enough.

Another cold blast of wind sweeps through the hall, rustling the papers on his desk.

Lì Huìfēng uses a paperweight to smooth the files and sits back into his chair.

Li Huifeng: Go now. Get some rest.

Li Huifeng: Your men are to be placed under the captain, Zhāng; he knows the county well. You will remain, but only as his backup.

Cheng Heguang: Why? I've done nothing wrong!

Li Huifeng: *sigh* Then you've not listened to a word I've said.

The water in the pot boils, the lid rattles, the steam whistles, and Lì Huìfēng pays it no attention.

Steam fills Chéng Héguāng's sight.

The pot at last boils over.

Cheng Heguang: Commander!

Cheng Heguang: Must the people's blood be spilled before we act?

Li Huifeng: Watch your tongue!

In the tea bowl on the desk, weak ripples form.

Cheng Heguang: ...

The young man stands solid, silent for a long time, rooted like a tree as the steam fades from him.

At last, he breaks the roots and turns.

Cheng Heguang: Perhaps I have not listened, Commander.

Cheng Heguang: Goodnight.

Cheng's House, Ancient Zhu County

The cool moon shines like a lantern over a dark lake.

Chéng Héguāng puts down a book and rubs his tired neck.

Cheng Heguang: *sigh* It's getting late.

He lights a blackened torch with a candle, holding the light as he steps into the dark.

Cheng Heguang: Zhòngní said, "One of virtue follows the course of the Mean; one of cunning turns from it."

Cheng Heguang: "Following the Mean, the virtuous acts in due measure. Turning from the Mean, the cunning moves without restraint."

He stops at the door, deep in thought.

Cheng Heguang: Fortunately, it's still not too late.

A street cat cries out nearby.

Cheng Heguang: Hm? That's ...

Night Watch: Fire! Fire!

A man runs in panic. Behind him, plumes of smoke leap and billow into the sky.

Night Watch: There's a fire at Chief Constable Chéng's house!

A Sow's Ear

SU-14

Side Room, School of Mei

Inside the room, a few Yao gather around Mayfly, helping her trim the fresh herbs she picked from the mountains.

Yam: Now that you know the path, you can go up the hill at your leisure and gather the elixir ingredients yourself. A little walk in the forest will do you good.

Mayfly: Thank you. I know the elixir helps with the practice, but isn't it a little unsettling, harvesting these herbs like this?

Yam: What's the matter? They're only plants, too young to form any spirit yet. It's not as if you're cutting down one of your own.

Paper Heron: Mayfly! Oh, uh, I mean Sister Mayfly, I thought that I should come check on you. See how you're getting on.

Mayfly: Look at that. Someone finally discovered the door. Though not much of a knocker, are you?

Yam: Good day, Grandmaster.

Paper Heron nods to the Yao, then walks around Mayfly, looking left and right.

Mayfly: What? What is it? You're giving me the withers.

Paper Heron: You've followed Rén's teachings for a few days now, hm? How do you feel?

Mayfly: Heron, you've asked me this a few times already.

Mayfly: I'm well, just as I was yesterday and the day before that. My strength's improving. I feel light and full of energy, even after a long day in the mountains.

Paper Heron puts her hands behind her back and circles Mayfly two more times, nodding each time.

Paper Heron: That's good. That's good then. Are you certain everything's fine? Nothing feels strange at all?

Mayfly: Absolutely!

Mayfly pats her chest as if to prove her health.

Mayfly: Why do you keep asking? Is something troubling you?

Paper Heron: Nothing makes me happier than seeing you well. But may I ask have you felt anything out of place while practicing Rén's methods?

Mayfly: Out of place? I don't know. But I've moved on to the second stage, "concentration and visualization."

She sits in a meditation pose and makes a hand gesture to cast an incantation.

Mayfly: Master Rén said that to meditate, I must sit in silence, concentrating my mind on an object and visualizing the inner deities until I find their presence. With consistent practice, the path to longevity will reveal itself.

Mayfly: That Mei tree nearby really is an ideal object to focus on. It seems to have been there for over a thousand years. Maybe it really does have a connection to the spiritual world.

Paper Heron: Are those her words?

Mayfly: Her exact words! I meditate about that tree day and night. I even see it in my dreams sometimes.

Mayfly: And Master Rén has been most generous. She even helps the other students using the power of her sword. How did she explain it?

Mayfly: Something like using the sword to clear the blockage in their body, freeing the flow of Qi, so they can advance more quickly with their training.

Mayfly: The first time I saw it, I almost thought she was about to poke a few holes in me. But instead, she just swiped it above my head, just like you did at the parade.

Mayfly: I even asked Brother Yam to teach me something from the third stage. You should see how well I can do it already.

Mayfly: Posture one, "Breeze in the Lungs." Face north, feet spread as wide as the shoulders.

She chants the words and shows Paper Heron what she has learned.

Mayfly: Master Rén told us that we must cultivate our bodies to align with the movement of Qi. Only then can our mortal flesh be prepared for longevity.

Mayfly: She said the cultivation would take about two months.

Paper Heron: Two months? Those were her words?

Mayfly: That's right.

Hearing Mayfly's words, Paper Heron's face changes. A hint of sternness cuts across her brow.

Butterfly: *panting*

Butterfly bursts in, panting and waving his hands.

Butterfly: Wonderful news! Karma finally came for that heartless Chief Constable Chéng!

Paper Heron: Chéng?

Hearing this, the other Yao gather around.

Hedgehog: You mean that grumpy, self-righteous constable that's been hunting us night and day?

Yam: I heard that he's been interrogating Yao, plucking his captive's hairs one by one.

Butterfly: Yes, that's him. What a pig! No offense to pigs!

Butterfly: I guess brutality must run in his blood. His family used to be bandits until they worked their way into the military. Not that they lasted long as soldiers. His own father turned out to be a crook!

Butterfly: He cut ties with his father to keep his post. But I don't believe it. If he's willing to throw us all behind bars just to make himself look good, then he's just as bad as the rest of them!

Yam: I'll bet he's rotten to the core. But what do you mean by "karma came for him"? Ah, tell us what happened.

Butterfly seizes the moment with excitement as he proceeds to describe the fire at the chief constable's home.

Mayfly: Isn't that the man we met at the gate?

Paper Heron: I believe so.

Her response is quick and muted, intending not to interrupt the clamor of the Yao.

Mayfly: I just don't understand why he hates us so much. We haven't hurt anyone. We just want to spread the Method of Longevity.

Hedgehog: Hardly a surprise. Those with long lives seldom care for the short-lived.

The words bring a harsh chill to the air as the other Yao look at each other and then to Paper Heron.

Yam: Hedgehog! The grandmaster is still here.

Paper Heron: Please, speak your mind. It is every creature's right.

Her words do little to break the sudden chill until Butterfly steers things back on topic.

Butterfly: Oh! I nearly forgot that awful chief had nearly locked up our grandmaster!

Butterfly: Grandmaster, did you start the fire to avenge us?

Paper Heron: Haha. No, I didn't. Though if anyone questions you on the matter, you may give them my name.

Butterfly: Grandmaster ...

Hearing this, all the Yao look at Paper Heron with awe.

Butterfly: It is a great honor to study under an avenging hero like you.

Butterfly: Please accept our humblest gratitude.

Yam: Thank you. Thank you for your heroic deeds.

Paper Heron: Aha ...

Their undeserved praise lands somewhere between funny and vexing, yet she can't help but realize the situation is growing beyond her control.

Yam: The grandmaster has taken our interests to heart, and we must repay her with our greatest effort. We must achieve longevity and spread the school's name.

All Yao: Achieve longevity! Spread the school's name!

The room has become a hubbub of cheers and excitement. But Mayfly does not seem to be participating. She stares up blankly, spots dancing in her vision like fireflies at dusk.

Mayfly: Huh, I ... What's going on?

Yam: Mayfly? Are you alright?

In a moment, Mayfly feels the world spin beneath her feet.

Paper Heron: ...!

As she tumbles, she sees Paper Heron glide toward her. Then all goes dark.

Yamen, Ancient Zhu County

The next day's sun rises as usual, but the Yamen's constables have a new topic to discuss.

Constable I: Did you hear? Those gentlemen we met yesterday have all fallen ill.

Constable I: It seems they've all been taken by a strange fever. Some fainted in an instant, while others went running and yelling on the streets in their undergarments. It was chaos.

Constable I: The chief was right. Whatever they were doing must have been dangerous.

Constable II: But I heard they hired a Daoist who cured them with nothing but water and a pinch of talisman ashes.

Constable I: Hmph. Well, that was easy. Shame the chief wasn't so lucky. To think a man could lose his home simply for doing his duty!

Constable II: Well, we don't know what caused the fire, do we?

Constable I: What else could it be? You were there. I think the chief found something important, and now they're desperate to get rid of him.

Constable II: I'm just glad I was on guard duty.

A shadow passes before the two men. They're struck silent with fear. But Chéng Héguāng does not even seem to notice them as he walks straight into the Yamen hall.

From his high seat, Lì Huìfēng looks at a plaque on the wall.

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, I understand it was your house that caught fire last night.

Cheng Heguang: It was.

Li Huifeng: It's a great relief to see you unharmed.

Li Huifeng: But I'm sorry for your loss. Take a few days. Find another place to stay and get some rest, will you?

Cheng Heguang: Much appreciated, Commander. That is precisely why I came.

Chéng Héguāng bows and then pours out his prepared words. It's clear immediately that he's had little rest.

Cheng Heguang: I was up late reviewing some case files. As it happened, the arsonists startled a cat as they approached. I was able to spy them from my window. Though I couldn't stop them in time.

Cheng Heguang: They were all Yao. I'm quite certain of it, as retaliation for the arrests I've made.

Cheng Heguang: Commander Lì, if I, a trained officer, couldn't protect my home from their schemes, what hope do the ordinary townspeople have?

Cheng Heguang: Please, permit me to bring them to justice and anyone else who shields them!

Li Huifeng: You—

Cheng Heguang: I know the Yamen is short-staffed. I won't ask for anyone's help until I have solid evidence.

Cheng Heguang: Now, I must take my leave. Good day, Commander!

He does not wait for Lì Huìfēng to say more and turns to leave.

High above them, the Yamen's bell is stirred by the wind, ringing out a long, clear note.

Into the Fire

SU-15

After breakfast, several Yao gather around Mayfly's bed.

Yam: Mayfly, you were out for the whole day!

Hedgehog: Brother Yam told me you were unwell, so I brought some sweet cakes. I thought you might like something to eat after your fall.

Mayfly: Hmm. Thank you.

Still half-asleep, Mayfly responds in a weak voice.

Paper Heron: Mayfly, it's me again.

Paper Heron: I've brought herbs to replenish your Qi. Don't worry. I checked. All cut from plants. No Yao were harmed.

Yam: Greetings, Grandmaster!

The Yao greet her enthusiastically. She nods to each of them in turn, then sets a bundle of herbs on the table.

Paper Heron: Ah, no need for those formalities, please. Would you give Mayfly and me a moment in private?

Yam: Of course. We'll leave you two alone.

Yam: Don't you hear the grandmaster? Come on, let's go.

The Yao nudge each other out of the room. Before long, only Paper Heron and Mayfly remain.

Mayfly: Paper Heron?

She senses something unusual about the moment and turns her head to find Paper Heron wearing a dour expression.

Paper Heron: Mayfly, you must stop practicing Rén's method.

Mayfly: Why?

Paper Heron: Your Qi is too unstable. At times, it surges like a boar, and at others, it falters. Haven't you noticed?

Mayfly: I ...

Paper Heron: You know I'm right, don't you? Your fall before was a warning. Your Qi is in decline.

Mayfly: But I've felt so much more energetic lately. Even my mind feels clearer than before.

Paper Heron: Yes. You have learned a great deal about how to control your Qi. You'd be in great shape, if that were all you were practicing.

Paper Heron: For you to advance further, your Qi must align with the Way, and your body must be strong enough to carry it.

Paper Heron: But if you're too weak, your Qi can become too great a burden. It could consume you.

Paper Heron: In the White Horse School, we always ensured our physique was strong enough to handle each step along the path.

Paper Heron: But Rén is moving too fast, pushing you forward with the power of the Longevity Sword. It's possible you may still succeed in the end, but ...

Paper Heron: You're risking both body and spirit for a tiny possibility.

Paper Heron: You could end up with nothing. Your body destroyed, your spirit extinguished. You need to stop and allow your body to recover.

Mayfly: For how long? Days? Weeks? Months?

Paper Heron: Given your condition, I'd say two months before you resume any training.

Mayfly: Two months?

Mayfly: Do you realize how little time I have? Winter's coming. I can't wait that long.

Paper Heron: I know.

Paper Heron: But if you continue in this fashion, I fear you may not live to see the winter.

Paper Heron: I can't stand by and watch you destroy yourself. Not just you. All the Yao. This isn't the right path for any of you.

Mayfly: Heron ...

Mayfly: I know, to you, two months may seem like nothing. I suppose it may seem like years pass you by in the blink of an eye, don't they?

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron gazes at the girl propped halfway up in bed. Her lips tremble faintly before she finally speaks.

Paper Heron: It's not quite as fleeting as a blink of an eye.

Mayfly: What would you do over the course of a year?

Paper Heron: I—

Mayfly: Wander the roads on your mule, through cloud-covered mountains, across gentle streams, beneath fragrant blooming peach trees.

Mayfly: And when the year ends, you'd go to Huanzhou for the temple fair, feeling the warmth of the flames dancing against your face, savoring the floral sweetness of sticky rice cakes.

Mayfly: Next year you'll travel further still, to see snow-covered plains, brush the fur of a moose, taste wine so strong that it burns your throat.

Mayfly: You never worry about the days you spend on the road or whether you have enough time to experience all the world has to offer.

The words hang bitterly on her lips, soon accompanied by wet tears flowing down her face.

Mayfly: But I won't live a full cycle of seasons.

One drop, two drops, three drops. The bedding covering her grows damp with a steady flow of tears.

Paper Heron can do nothing to stem their flow. So, she simply waits, watching her friend in tender silence.

Mayfly: To you, a day, a month, a year, it means nothing.

Mayfly: But for Yao like me, a year is a lifetime—our only lifetime.

Mayfly: I want to live, even just a little longer, to see more, feel more. I can't allow myself to waste even a moment.

Mayfly: In a thousand years, my name could still be carved on that stone. But I won't live to know if it's there next spring. So, why must you stop me?

Paper Heron: ...

There are barbs on the question, too sharp to swallow, too true to ignore. She chews on it a long while, hoping to reach an answer.

Paper Heron: I didn't intend to hurt your feelings when I carved that stone.

Paper Heron: Is it your wish then? To live as long as the stones?

Mayfly: What? What do you mean?

Paper Heron smiles, but a trace of sorrow lingers at the corners of her mouth.

Paper Heron: Besides Inner Alchemy and Rén's method, there is a third way to escape the flow of time, one that has been kept a secret.

Paper Heron: It doesn't take hundreds of years of training, nor does it endanger your Qi. All it costs is your school, a sword, and a hundred years sealed in a tree.

Paper Heron: When the seal breaks, all you once knew will be gone—friends and enemies alike. You will no longer laugh nor hate, and your senses will dull.

Paper Heron: Sweet or sour, salt or spice, it will all taste the same.

Paper Heron: People will cheer at the blazing fire flowers, yet to you, the flames will be as mild as a passing breeze, their excitement like a language you no longer understand.

Paper Heron: Your memories will stay. You'll always recall how the morning mist felt on your face, the crispness of spring water as it flowed through your fingers, but you will never feel them again.

Paper Heron: You will become like a stone. Is that what you want?

Mayfly: Is that how the world feels to you?

Paper Heron: ...

She doesn't reply.

Mayfly lowers her head, her fingers twisting together as if trying to hold the weight of her tangled thoughts.

After a moment's consideration, she takes something from her pocket.

It's the amulet that was trampled by her and repaired by Paper Heron.

Mayfly: But Heron, you've already shown me a way.

Mayfly: This amulet—I spent every coin I had on it, just for a chance to get through the city gate.

Mayfly: It didn't work like I'd hoped, and I felt so foolish for believing in it. But you repaired it, even improved it, so that I could make it through.

Mayfly: I may be just a wind-tossed reed, but that doesn't mean I'm unworthy of the wonders of this world. Isn't that what you wanted to tell me?

Mayfly: I'm willing to take the chance to lose everything or gain the world.

Mayfly: You once said that fate presents an opportunity to every one of us.

Mayfly: You've had yours, and I need to take mine.

Paper Heron: You mean that you want to follow Rén's method no matter the danger?

Mayfly: Yes.

Mayfly: *cough* She-She has shown us a way to live beyond our years.

Mayfly: Even if it's dangerous, I want to take the chance to truly live.

Paper Heron: ...

Paper Heron: I understand.

She knows it won't be useful to argue her point any longer. She rises to her feet and taps the herbs on the table.

Paper Heron: Just remember to drink my herbal brew, eh?

The door stands ajar. Other Yao peer inside with curiosity. Paper Heron walks past them without a word.

In the dazzling morning light, she walks straight toward the courtyard.

To Heaven!

SU-16

Morning light renders the Mei petals nearly translucent under the sun. Beneath the Mei tree, young Yao practice in formation.

Paper Heron: Where is your master?

School of Mei Believer I: Grandmaster Heron, I believe she left to attend to some personal matters.

Paper Heron: Erm, I think it best you no longer call me that. Your master has taken a path away from my teachings. I am now nothing more than an ordinary Daoist to you.

School of Mei Believer I: Oh, I see.

They exchange worried glances, but seeing the pain beneath her smile, they choose not to trouble her.

Paper Heron: When she returns, please tell her that I want to have a word with her here. Is there a place we could speak?

School of Mei Believer I: Certainly, Grand, uh, I mean, Master Heron.

White clouds drift past the sun, casting shadows eastward.

After roughly half a day, Master Rén returns to the school. Before the Mei tree, Paper Heron stands alone.

Master Ren: You wish to speak with me?

Paper Heron: I do. The day's been quiet, and I've found myself reminiscing on the old days. Would you join me for a chat beneath the Mei tree?

She smiles as she gestures toward the tree in the courtyard.

Master Ren: This tree?

Master Rén glances at the red Mei tree. It's scrawny for its years. Staring up at it, she can't help but laugh coldly.

Master Ren: Why? There isn't much to it. It could take a thousand years before it rivals the largest Mei tree in town.

Paper Heron: Let's just talk about the old days, eh?

Paper Heron: When the White Horse School attempted to subdue the Beast Lǎnzhū, they were taken by surprise by rival schools. We lost all our most capable masters in the battle.

Paper Heron: Seeing no other way, my grandmaster shattered one of the two Longevity Swords, releasing the Qi within to create a seal. The last student of the school and the beast were frozen in that moment, sealed inside a Mei tree.

Master Ren: A hundred years later, a Painted-Skin Yao faced her celestial tribulation under the same tree. Lightning struck both her and the tree, and the seal was broken.

Master Ren: The lightning nearly destroyed the Yao. The White Horse student, freed from the seal and surprised by such a turn of fate, saved the dying Yao and taught her the Daoist arts. We both know the story.

Paper Heron: Yes, you remember every detail of it.

Master Ren: I could never forget.

Paper Heron: I gave you the remaining sword and taught you the way of Inner Alchemy, but I never asked you to take the name of a White Horse student. I knew the school was lost to history.

Master Ren: The school is gone, yes, but their duty to control the Xiǎndào Beast was unfinished.

Master Ren: What's the purpose of this, Heron?

She shakes her head, gazing out into the distance toward another giant Mei tree far beyond their sight—a sister of the school's own centerpiece.

Paper Heron: What is your purpose, Rén?

Paper Heron: You told your students to channel their Qi into the Mei tree. Why?

Her old student looks at her and simply laughs.

Master Ren: So you've found out about that.

Paper Heron: I'm not easily fooled.

Master Rén lets the words roll over her as she settles herself at the stone table beneath the tree's shadow.

Master Ren: I know you disagree with my methods, but whether you agree or not, this is what is best for the students.

Master Ren: They're not like you. None of them have the talent or lifespan to properly cultivate longevity.

Master Ren: Had you been in my place, you likely wouldn't have taken them on at all. But I want to give them a chance.

Master Ren: After all, what would a talented master like you know of the life of a lowly Yao, of our struggles and desires?

Paper Heron: I do not mean to question your teachings, Rén. I only need to know why you've focused their Qi there, of all places.

Master Ren: My, my, when did you become so impatient, Heron?

ching

Master Rén casts a familiar incantation, and the white sword reappears in the air.

Master Ren: You trusted me with the sword, and I have endeavored to honor that trust by sharing it. I was once a short-lived Yao myself. It is only natural that I wish to help my kind.

Master Ren: Combining Inner Alchemy with the power of the Longevity Sword, I developed a method for our kind to overcome their disadvantages.

Master Ren: The sword can hold and release Qi. It gives, and it takes. Through it, I work to bring the Yao the lives they deserve.

Master Ren: Should they succeed, there will be one more Daoist master to carry the Method forward.

Master Ren: And if they fail, their remaining Qi is gathered within the Mei tree to aid us in subduing the beast when it next awakens. Either way, the outcome is favorable.

Master Ren: And either way, their deaths will not be in vain.

Paper Heron: You lay it out so plainly. Do your students know?

Paper Heron: Do they know their master sees them as mere fuel for her designs?

Master Ren: Hahaha ... Does it matter? Each one of them knows longevity comes at a price.

Master Ren: Do you think any of them would have joined me if they were not willing to risk their lives?

Master Ren: Does any price we pay matter if it means subduing the beast?

She laughs again, but there's no joy in it. Paper Heron turns her head away.

Master Ren: "No matter the cost," I said. I gave you my word. This is but a small portion of the sacrifices I am prepared to make.

Paper Heron: You also promised to do your best to care for your students.

Master Ren: If the beast breaks free, every one of them will perish, whether on that fateful day or any other, they have the same choice: aid me, or else die a pointless death.

Master Ren: I should hope you know me well enough to trust that I do not undertake this selfishly. Do you not see that I am doing only what must be done?

Paper Heron: Keeping Lǎnzhū subdued will not require nearly this much Qi.

Paper Heron: With the Qi you've gathered, the lives you've sacrificed ...

Paper Heron: You could kill the beast.

At some point, the wind in the courtyard had stilled completely.

Master Rén raises her head and fixes Paper Heron with a mocking stare.

Master Ren: You were given a weapon of magnificent power—the capability to sense the cycle of all things and even manipulate the wax and wane of life itself.

Master Ren: Yet the White Horse School merely used it to clear the blockage of Qi in Lǎnzhū. An all-powerful sword reduced to a tamer's whip.

Paper Heron: Because Lǎnzhū must not die.

Master Ren: Paper Heron, you of all people, are the last I expected to say such a thing. You lost your school, your friends, your masters, to this beast, and you would have it remain a threat forever?

Master Ren: What good would come of that?

Paper Heron: The Xiǎndào Beasts play a necessary part in the workings of Heaven. A far greater danger may come of its death, one that extends far beyond Huanzhou. Have I not taught you as much?

Master Ren: And why should I follow your teachings, hm? Why should I bind my students, and their students alike, to an endless cycle of subduing the beast?

Paper Heron: ...!

Master Ren: Humans have a strange attachment to their "legacies." But to be Yao is to be defined by one short life. I intend to make mine echo through the ages.

Master Ren: Lǎnzhū will perish and the cycle will end, and all for a small price.

Master Ren: No more endless duties passed from hand to hand, no more deaths in service of legacy. Our school will never suffer as yours did.

Master Ren: As for me, I will share the power released from the dead beast with my students, and together, we will ascend to immortality!

Paper Heron: ...

She takes a deep breath. As she opens her eyes again, her voice is cold as winter.

Paper Heron: This goes against the Way. It isn't natural.

Master Ren: What does it mean for a thing to be natural?

Master Ren: Would it not have been natural for you to let me die under that Mei tree?

Master Ren: But you didn't. My very life is proof that the Way can be defied.

Master Ren: Perhaps there is risk in diverting the cycles of Heaven. But how much greater are the rewards?

Master Ren: If there is risk, I take it gladly. I will slay the beast and free Huanzhou and its people from its threat.

Master Ren: Then, I will ascend.

Paper Heron: And if you fail? What will happen to the people?

Master Ren: I won't fail.

Silence follows, broken by the returning wind as it rustles the Mei tree's branches.

Master Rén doesn't betray a hint of doubt, but her former master's reply comes like a sharp cut.

Paper Heron: Your pride has blinded you.

Suddenly, arcane light flashes before Master Rén's eyes.

She raises her brush in defense but is driven back a dozen steps.

Master Ren: Hahaha. Are you really the same woman I called Master? All I have done is speak honestly, yet you answer with a lethal strike!

Master Ren: You lecture me about pride, then dare to take my life?

Master Ren: But if you choose to stand in my way, then I must take yours!

Master Ren: Heh! Hah!

Paper Heron: Have I trained you so poorly?

Paper Heron strikes at Master Rén's weak point, but her opponent abandons resistance, instead raising the Longevity Sword like a hostage.

Paper Heron: What?

Caught off guard, Paper Heron is forced to withdraw her attack mid-strike. She barely retrieves the Longevity Sword, leaving a scar on the sheath. Yet she cannot escape the backlash of her own arcane skill.

Master Ren: Hahahaha ...

Master Ren: Why do you stay your hand, Heron? Strike me down, if you truly believe it to be just! Or is it that you care more for this sword than any living thing?

Master Ren: You have lost more than your senses, Master. Make whatever claims you like, but I see your empty heart. All that matters to you is your legacy, your mission! And I was only a tool.

Master Ren: Are you now too blind to see how deep your hypocrisy runs?

Paper Heron: Enough.

Master Ren: *cough*

Master Rén clutches her chest and coughs up blood.

Master Ren: All the decades I have given in preparation. You cannot stop me now, not when I am this close to success!

She raises her brush, gathering energy as veins bulge on her forehead. At last, she lunges at her in a furious charge.

Paper Heron: What?

Paper Heron retreats a step but fails to evade the attack entirely. Sharp pain tears through her chest.

Seeing that Master Rén shows no sign of relenting, Paper Heron has no choice but to cast another incantation.

Master Ren: Hmm?

The smoke clears. Before Master Rén stands only a paper figure clutching a sword.

Master Ren: Hmph.

All Yao: Master! Should we go after her?

Master Ren: Go. Whether dead or alive, she must not escape with the Longevity Sword. Bring it to me intact!

All Yao: Yes, Master.

The Yao scatter.

She casts one final sneering glance at the scrawny Mei tree in the courtyard, then flicks her sleeves and leaves.

An Eastern Promise

SU-17

Night Watch: The night is dry. Beware of fires!

Night Watch: The night is dry. Beware of fires!

The night watch's gong reverberates into the night. Only then does Chéng Héguāng jump from the tree, studying the alley before him intently.

Cheng Heguang: This is where that strange parade was last seen. Hm?

Yang Wu: Hey, you! What are you doing out here at this hour?

Du Liu: Wǔ! It's her.

Chéng Héguāng turns toward the source of the sound. Yáng Wǔ and Dù Liù have cornered a wounded woman.

Cheng Heguang: Yáng Wǔ, Dù Liù, what's going on?

Seeing him, the two exchange an awkward glance.

Paper Heron: Well now, fate always finds a way to put enemies in your path, eh?

Yang Wu: Chief! We were on patrol duty. We ran into the Daoist. She was the one with the School of Mei.

Chéng Héguāng narrows his eyes as he spots the woman. His right hand falling instinctively to his blade.

Cheng Heguang: What are you doing here?

Paper Heron: Long story.

He ignores her response, instead, sweeping his eyes over the woman's bloodstained robes.

Du Liu: Chief?

Cheng Heguang: ...

Cheng Heguang: Return to your patrol. I will take her to the Yamen later.

Yang Wu: But Chief, the commander ordered us to—

Dù Liù gives his partner a prod with his elbow and takes over the conversation.

Du Liu: Let's go, Wǔ. I'm sure the chief has his own score to settle with her.

Yang Wu: His own score ... Aah.

Yáng Wǔ at last realizes what's going on and nods knowingly.

Cheng Heguang: Just a few questions. Is that alright?

Du Liu: Of course. Take your time, Chief. We were never here.

The two cup their fists in a salute and hurry away.

Paper Heron: Much appreciated. Seems you and I just can't seem to avoid each other.

Paper Heron leans against the wall. She coughs, and a small trickle of blood escapes her lips.

Paper Heron: Would you be willing to hear what I have to say? I need a favor. It's about the safety of this city.

The believers hold torches, gathering in the square beside the pond.

Master Ren: As difficult as it is to believe, we must face the truth: Paper Heron has turned against us.

School of Mei Believer II: But wasn't she your guide to longevity? Why would she turn her back on us after all her efforts?

School of Mei Believer III: She's been kind to us, and we have paid her our respect. How did it come to this?

Master Ren: Her long life has hardened her heart to us.

Master Ren: But when we succeed and join her in longevity, her status and authority will be challenged.

Mayfly: I can't believe this.

Master Ren: The moment she learned of our goal, she chose to become an obstacle. Now that she has taken the Longevity Sword, her position is clear.

Master Ren: Remember, the Qi from that sword is instrumental to our success. Without it, we will not survive.

The Yao below the platform grow restless. Emotions flash across their faces—surprise, sorrow, and anger.

Hedgehog: I knew it. At first, I thought she cared when she gave us those amulets, but when she challenged Master Rén, I realized it was all a farce.

Badger: All that talk about the "right path" and serving the Way, as if we had the time to do any of that!

Badger: We sacrificed so much for longevity. We can't fail now!

Master Ren: Without the sword, the Quelling Array will weaken. I can still subdue the beast with elixirs, but it will leave me without the strength to shield you from harm.

Master Ren: But we still have a chance. I wounded her when she wrestled the sword from me. We must take it back before she recovers.

Master Ren: So I bid you: go forth and find her. Secure the sword at any cost!

Master Ren: But before you risk your lives this night, hear these words: The path before us is set. We will slay Lǎnzhū and draw upon its power to ascend. If you do not share our purpose, you may still leave.

The crowd erupts, heated protests and arguments drowning out all else.

School of Mei Believer IV: My family is long gone, and I wouldn't have made it this far without Master Rén's teachings. I will stand with her and bring the sword back!

School of Mei Believer V: I traveled all the way from Liaodong, and I'd have died last month if not for Master Rén's help. I'll do whatever I can to return the sword!

School of Mei Believer IV: Either we die tonight, or we live forever! I stand with Master Rén!

Yam: It seems this is the only path left for us.

Butterfly: Everyone else agrees.

Mayfly and Butterfly exchange a meaningful glance. Lost amid the fervent crowd, they join their growing cries, hesitant and then wholeheartedly.

Butterfly: Then, I, too, will stand with Master Rén!

Mayfly: I-I stand with Master Rén!

All Yao: We all stand with Master Rén!

Oaths and shouts of support spread like waves in a stone-lined pond, pouring back over themselves until the once tranquil courtyard is a cacophony of sound.

Then their master raises her hand, signaling the believers to quiet down.

Master Ren: You have my thanks.

Master Ren: Do not let fear get the better of you. The final hour approaches; the array is ready. I shall do all that is in my power to enact our plan.

Master Ren: With or without the sword, meet me under the Mei tree at the first double-hour this night. Together, we will seek our ascension to longevity!

A century-old tale can be told in mere sentences.

Chéng Héguāng looks at her in astonishment, fitting the scattered fragments of his investigation into a clear picture at last.

Cheng Heguang: So then, those dead animals were the Yao who failed in their pursuit of the Method.

Paper Heron nods.

Paper Heron: Lǎnzhū will soon awaken. If we don't stop Rén, her actions may throw the balance of life out of order and put all of Huanzhou in danger.

Paper Heron: We need to evacuate the townsfolk as soon as we can. Time's running out.

Paper Heron: But I'm wounded. It will be a while before I can move again.

Paper Heron: Will you aid me in this?

His mouth opens in surprise, but the words don't come. After a moment's deliberation, he makes his decision.

Cheng Heguang: This is no small favor. It'll take the effort of every soldier and constable in town to evacuate the people in time.

Cheng Heguang: Even if I believe you, my superiors won't be so easily convinced.

Paper Heron: Then how about this?

She bows her head and draws the Longevity Sword from within her robes, channeling a thread of Qi into it.

The white blade emanates a cold bright light. It seems almost alive for a moment.

Paper Heron: Long ago, when His Eminence walked the land, two white horse tails were bestowed upon him as a reward for his service to the Way. Those tails were forged into a pair of jade swords.

Paper Heron: I carry only one of them. A rare Daoist implement passed down to me by my master, from his master before him. It means more to me than my life.

Paper Heron: I swear on it. I have told you nothing but the truth.

Paper Heron: Were you to present this sword to your people, might they ...?

Cheng Heguang: It'll do.

He fixes his sharp gaze over the Mei pattern and the Bagua array.

Cheng Heguang: The high lords of this town have close ties with the School of Mei.

Cheng Heguang: They will recognize this sword.

Paper Heron: Then take it. Look after it well.

She sheathes the sword and offers it to him.

He receives it with both hands, feeling the blade's weight.

Cheng Heguang: You-You're leaving the sword to me, just like that?

She lowers her eyes, managing a weak smile.

Paper Heron: This sword means more to me than my life, yes. But I once valued it so greatly that I lost sight of what is truly important. In the end, it's only a sword.

Paper Heron: And what purpose does a sword have if it is not used to protect?

Cheng Heguang: Well said!

Cheng Heguang: You have my word. I will protect it with my life.

Cheng Heguang: Should anything go wrong, I will bring my head to you.

In the deep darkness of the night, Paper Heron cannot see the young man's face, but his resolute tone paints a picture the light could not.

She lifts herself just enough to reach his shoulder.

Paper Heron: Now, what would I do with a young man's head, eh? Worry not. I'm a Qi reader. I can trace the sword wherever it goes.

Paper Heron: Now go. Rén won't give up the sword easily, so be careful. I'll find you once I'm back on my feet.

Distant screams and wails drift through the air. Across the county, fires burst and flicker against the night sky.

Yao shadows slide across the wall. Any doubt that Paper Heron speaks the truth vanishes from him.

Cheng Heguang: What if ...

Paper Heron: Just go!

Chéng Héguāng grits his teeth, takes the Longevity Sword to his side, and leaps onto the high wall.

Paper Heron: Chéng! I owe you for this.

Paper Heron: For setting aside grudges and helping me. I know the School of Mei burned down your home. If we survive this, I'll help you build a new one.

Cheng Heguang: The School of Mei?

At these words, the young man atop the wall turns around, his usually stern face broken into a rare, wild-eyed smile.

Cheng Heguang: To tell you the truth ...

Cheng Heguang: I set that fire myself.

Paper Heron: Wait, what?

Her eyes widen in surprise, but the tiles stand empty before she can respond.

Before her, Yao surge from the shadows in their true forms, eyes gleaming green beneath the moon.

Paper Heron: Well now, never judge a book by its cover, eh?

School of Mei Believer IV: Heron! Return the sword at once!

Paper Heron: And if I refuse?

Paper Heron: Come, let me see how Rén trains her students!

Yamen, Ancient Zhu County

The Yamen is silent. The bell beneath the roof's beastly guardians has not moved.

Chéng Héguāng crosses over the gate. In a few strides, he reaches the still-lit study and extends his hand toward the door.

???: Commander Lì ...

The unfamiliar voice stops him in place.

Cheng Heguang: There's someone else inside?

After a moment's consideration, he crouches and places his ear up to the door.

???: Haha! It truly was a masterstroke.

???: Had it not been for your arrests, the Yao wouldn't have turned to me so quickly, or in such numbers.

Li Huifeng: As an otter drives fish into the lakes and the eagle leads birds into the woods, heh heh, the hunter must know where his prey will run.

???: You have honored your word. I will keep your efforts in mind when I next speak to your superiors.

???: I have one more favor to ask.

The conversation grows indistinct as fury clouds Chéng Héguāng's focus.

Clarity returns. But only after he finds himself standing resolutely behind a door that has been kicked wide open.

Cheng Heguang: Lì Huìfēng!

Pain and Gain

SU-18

Study, Yamen

Cheng Heguang: Urgh!

The door swings back toward him, and he instinctively pushes it aside. Ink droplets fly across his face.

He sidesteps, revealing the Longevity Sword strapped to his back.

Master Ren: You do indeed work wonders, Commander. My lost sword has shown up at your door before I even asked for it.

The elegant woman in Daoist robes withdraws her brush mockingly, looking over to the commander.

He offers no response; instead, his eyes linger on the blade Chéng Héguāng now holds half-drawn.

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, take a seat.

He gestures toward a chair in the room. Chéng Héguāng doesn't budge, his hand trembling over the grip of the sword.

Li Huifeng: Pardon the intrusion, Master Rén. This is Chéng, that subordinate I've mentioned, a promising young man. He has proven to be of great use.

Chéng Héguāng makes it clear he will not offer a greeting. Lì Huìfēng decides not to insist before introducing him to the woman as if his arrival had been nothing more than a social visit.

Li Huifeng: Héguāng, this is Master Rén, the head of the School of Mei and a respected friend of Lord Lù. I have told her of your hardships, and she has expressed her sympathies.

Master Ren: Well met, Chief Constable Chéng. Your commander speaks highly of you. I hope you do not bear me any ill will. I understand some blame my school for your unfortunate fire.

Master Ren: You have suffered a great deal of troubles. I can only imagine how far your star would rise if it weren't for your unfortunate parentage.

Master Ren: If fate has led us to meet this day, it must have its reasons. I cannot do much, but I may offer some aid to your career.

She removes a token from her waist and tosses it before the young constable.

Master Ren: A personal gift from the venerable Lord Lù. His influence carries quite far, I'm sure you know. I wonder how he might look upon the constable that returned my sword to me.

Master Ren: With our recommendation, a promotion would certainly follow.

Chéng Héguāng maintains his grip on the blade, not sparing the token on the ground even the courtesy of a glance.

Cheng Heguang: You-You've been conspiring all along. All that talk of evidence, hmph, it was just an attempt to stall me.

Cheng Heguang: You've been in their pocket from the start!

Li Huifeng: Héguāng.

His commander interjects, attempting to douse the young constable's fiery accusations.

Li Huifeng: Pick up the token. Is this not what you've always wanted? To redeem your family name?

Li Huifeng: Take it. Your long-cherished wish can come true.

His voice drips out at a measured pace, as always.

Chéng Héguāng stares in disbelief. The blade's shadow on the wall wavers.

Cheng Heguang: Lì Huìfēng! Have you lost your senses?

Cheng Heguang: Do you hear yourself? If she takes this sword, she will bring calamity upon us all!

Cheng Heguang: Not only do you act as an agent of evil, allowing her to harm your people, but you even dare to profit from their suffering! You—

Master Ren: Hahaha ...

The Daoist woman begins to laugh, as if their exchange had only been an amusing story.

Master Ren: "Agent of evil"? "Profit from their suffering"? Have you looked at yourself, Chief Chéng?

Master Ren: Haven't you been arresting Yao day and night for the sake of your own glory? Are you not the very reason they sought refuge at my door?

Cheng Heguang: That is a perversion of the truth! Hah! I should've seen it before—the Reversion Bell. How else could our town have come by a Daoist relic? The parade itself was your doing!

Master Ren: For all of the Yao you imprisoned and interrogated, you still had no knowledge of our designs, did you?

Master Ren: Those poor, pitiful Yao, only wanting another day to live, crushed beneath the chief's boots, in his hunger for power.

Cheng Heguang: Lies! They were arrested for deceiving the people, not for my benefit!

Master Ren: Hah! Deceiving the people! And what lie was it that drove them to beg for the Method of Longevity?

Master Ren: Were they deceived, or did they only accuse me out of spite after being turned away? Some "investigation"!

Master Ren: As you strode through that prison, did it ever cross your mind that the truth may be the very opposite?

Cheng Heguang: ...!

Bird: We only want a little more time in this world, Chief Chéng. Why must you stand in our way?

Bird: Only a few borrowed days! We never hurt anyone!

Bird: I've done nothing wrong! Release me! Every moment is precious!

Cold sweat drips over Chéng Héguāng's temples. He realizes with some pain that this woman speaks the truth.

Master Ren: Hmph. You needn't trouble yourself, Chief Chéng. In fact, I should thank you.

Master Ren: Were it not for your diligence, I'd have never gathered so much Qi in such a short time.

Master Ren: Hmph. Whether Huanzhou is saved or meets its ruin this night, much of the credit shall be yours.

Cheng Heguang: You—

He glares, eyes raging with fury, but the Daoist Master no longer seems willing to entertain him as she drifts to Lì Huìfēng's side.

Master Ren: You humans are odd indeed. Have you not spent your entire life attempting to cleanse yourself of your father's dishonor?

Master Ren: Why shy away from your actions now, when they might finally be rewarded?

Cheng Heguang: That's not why I did it! I didn't—

Li Huifeng: Héguāng.

Before he realizes it, Lì Huìfēng has already retrieved the token from the floor.

Chéng Héguāng sees it clearly for the first time. A symbol of power, inlaid with gold and silver.

Li Huifeng: Pick up the token, and put down the sword.

Li Huifeng: You have heard too much; you can't stay here any longer. Take the token and go. Find a new life for yourself elsewhere.

He brushes away the dust and extends the token toward Chéng Héguāng.

Li Huifeng: Or have you forgotten the vow you made to me?

Cheng Heguang: I ...

Li Huifeng: What is your want?

Cheng Heguang: My father brought shame not only upon himself, but upon those who placed their trust in him. I swear I will not make the same mistake.

Cheng Heguang: It is said that a warrior is a warrior, and a bandit is a bandit. But I am not my father, and I will remove the stain on my family name!

Cheng Heguang: Commander, all I ask is one chance!

Master Ren: *sigh* Chief Chéng, I pray you would not hold my words against me. They were spoken in the heat of the moment.

Master Ren: *sneer* You are human, and we are Yao. Beings of different kinds are never of one mind. Our natures simply do not align.

Master Ren: So your interests clash with ours. Why blame yourself for what was bound to happen?

Between truth and lies, their voices grow distant, then near, back and forth like a swinging pendulum.

Though the autumn wanes outside, inside the air feels thick and stifling.

Cheng Heguang: A warrior is a warrior, and a bandit is a bandit.

Cheng Heguang: Beings of different kinds are never of one mind.

Cheng Heguang: So that's how it is. Hahaha, hahahaha.

He's been backed into the corner.

No escape remains.

Cheng Heguang: Commander, for the last time—

Cheng Heguang: Are you aware that Huanzhou now lingers at the edge of destruction?

Under the lamplight, his mentor's expression remains unclear. But his voice holds steady and darkly calm.

Li Huifeng: Yes and no—

Li Huifeng: Does it even matter?

Cheng Heguang: Hahahaha, fair point! A fair point!

All his rage, shock, and disappointment dissolve into a single bitter laugh.

In that instant, Chéng Héguāng's blade leaves its sheath as ink strikes toward his waist.

In a flash, several oil lamps are extinguished. The token shatters into worthless scrap under the ink's force.

Cheng Heguang: I should have known.

Cheng Heguang: For years, I worked to prove myself to you, hoping my merits would prove the strength of my character. I was so fixated on my goal that I failed to see the truth.

Cheng Heguang: Now I see it clearly. Seeking favor from people like you only led me deeper into dishonor.

He shakes his head ruefully, mourning years of wasted effort.

Cheng Heguang: I never cared about promotions or power. I only ever wanted to do what was right.

Cheng Heguang: If I picked up that token, I would be betraying all that I believe in.

He tears his Chief Constable's token from his waist and throws it to Lì Huìfēng's feet.

Cheng Heguang: Commander, you claim that it doesn't matter what you know. You think that I should be a soldier and follow what you say.

Cheng Heguang: But I see now, I am a bandit, and I always will be!

Cheng Heguang: I want no place among your kind!

In the flickering lamplight, Lì Huìfēng's blade flashes forward before his eyes.

Li Huifeng: Your father was once my friend. After what happened, I took it upon myself to aid you through your difficulties.

Li Huifeng: But it seems you're too stubborn to be helped.

The two men meet in a furious clash of blades and incantations, reducing the room around them to shambles.

But at the height of their deadlock, Master Rén intervenes, suddenly striking Chéng Héguāng with her palm, forcing him back several steps.

Master Ren: You hopeless fool! Surrender the sword at once!

Cheng Heguang: I gave my word to protect it.

Cheng Heguang: I've made many mistakes. I will not make another.

Cheng Heguang: If you want the sword, you'll have to kill me first!

The Daoist flicks her sleeves dramatically as her shadow on the wall transforms like a serpent shedding its skin.

Her gentle facade shatters, falling away like a cascade of ash.

Cheng Heguang: —?

Master Rén draws her iron brush and closes the distance in mere strides.

Cheng Heguang: Ugh! Can't hold out much longer.

Dazed by her assault, he nearly misses the slip of red paper drifting past him.

Cheng Heguang: ...!

Master Ren: Eyes forward. There's no escape now!

Cheng Heguang: Ugh!

Paper Heron: Chéng!

Cheng Heguang: Take the sword!

Paper Heron: My thanks!

Paper Heron: I hope I'm not too late!

Significance of the Insignificant

SU-19

Paper Heron catches the sword midair, using its edge to deflect the ink droplets surging toward her from the side.

Seeing this, Master Rén lunges forward half a step, barring the doorway.

Master Ren: Return the sword to me.

Paper Heron: Not while I yet breathe.

Master Ren: So be it. It will spare me from listening to another of your worthless lectures.

Master Ren: You entrusted that sword to me long ago. Why not simply hand it over and return to your carefree wandering?

Master Ren: Perhaps you aren't so free from desire!

Amid the flames, blades flash. Paper Heron and Master Rén remain locked in combat.

Beams blaze above them. Chéng Héguāng dodges as collapsing timbers fall nearby, only now realizing that his commander has vanished within the smoke and fled into the night.

Suddenly, as if ten thousand drums were struck at once, the earth trembles and quakes.

Cheng Heguang: What's going on?

Paper Heron whips around toward the patch of sky visible through the study's courtyard.

Paper Heron: Lǎnzhū.

Paper Heron: The beast has awakened.

Master Ren: The moment has come at last. You are weak, Heron. Your Qi will not be enough to contend with Lǎnzhū.

Master Ren: Keep the sword if you must. I will ascend with or without it!

Her triumphant laughter rings out as she leaps away over the growing fires.

Cheng Heguang: She—

Paper Heron: Don't, Chéng. *cough*

Paper Heron: It's too late.

Darkness engulfs half the sky, devouring the moonlight. The earth trembles as if it were breathing. Panicked civilians flood the streets.

Fire-lit columns of smoke rise over the other half. Beams collapse, bricks crumble. The calamity has arrived.

County Resident II: Earthquake! It's an earthquake!

County Resident II: The ground is splitting apart! I saw someone fall into it. Help! Get help!!

County Resident III: My house!

Cheng Heguang: This-This is Lǎnzhū's power.

Paper Heron: Rén has agitated it, forcing its Qi to surge just so she can siphon it for herself. She is inviting a disaster greater than any known before.

Against the swirling trample of the helpless civilians, a parade advances, chanting above the panicked din around them.

School of Mei Believers: Withered grass devours bone. On icy plain the spirits moan.

School of Mei Believers: When the city falls, the Immortal descends. Longevity granted, no death, no end.

County Resident II: What-What on earth is happening?

School of Mei Believer II: The path lies untraveled, but the end has begun!

School of Mei Believer II: Seek salvation in longevity!

County Resident II: Salvation? Longevity? How?

County Resident II: Help us, Immortal One!

Cheng Heguang: Hmph. They think Rén is here to save them. Ridiculous!

Paper Heron stands amid the wreckage of a street, feeling strangely helpless despite herself.

She holds the Longevity Sword, bows her head, and lets out a deep sigh.

Paper Heron: This is all because of me. I brought all of this upon us.

Paper Heron: When the White Horse School collapsed, I couldn't bear to see the Method of Longevity disappear. I believed that sharing it with Rén would be for the benefit of all.

Paper Heron: But I forgot that with fortune comes disaster, and how easily a well-intended deed can lead to peril.

Paper Heron: The Method itself is not wicked, and those who put their faith in Rén are not evil in nature, but I-I entrusted a dangerous tool to the wrong person.

Paper Heron: I am the one to blame.

It's difficult to read her expression. He cannot help but see the hellish disaster reflected in the depths of her eyes.

Paper Heron: And I must be the one to end it.

Paper Heron surveys the scene ahead of her.

Paper Heron: You need to leave.

Cheng Heguang: Leave? Where to?

Paper Heron: Anywhere but here. If you go now and run day and night, you may yet survive.

Cheng Heguang: Why?

She looks up, surprised at the fury in Chéng Héguāng's tone.

Cheng Heguang: If I flee now, how am I any different from those cowardly lords?

Cheng Heguang: I may no longer be Chief Constable, but I still answer to my conscience!

Paper Heron: You don't fear death?

Cheng Heguang: I fear living in regret.

He clutches his fists. The fire in his eyes burns brighter than any mere reflection.

Cheng Heguang: You trusted me with your sword. I cannot repay you with abandonment.

Cheng Heguang: Lì Huìfēng has fled, but I still have his token to command the other constables.

Cheng Heguang: I will aid you in any way I can.

Paper Heron: But this is no ordinary crisis. I cannot guarantee your safety.

Cheng Heguang: All the more reason.

Cheng Heguang: I'll come find you once I instruct the other constables to evacuate the townsfolk.

Seeing the young man's resolve, Paper Heron nods.

Paper Heron: Be careful.

They exchange a quick glance. Chéng Héguāng turns and leaps back into the burning ruins. Paper Heron casts an incantation and vanishes from the spot.

No Turning Back

SU-20

Mei Tree, Ancient Zhu County

Lightning tears through the thick clouds, shaking the earth with each strike.

Master Rén stands before the Mei tree, unmoved by the clashing of earth and sky. Her students sit around her in a ring with muted, fearful reverence. Mayfly is among them, sitting at the front.

Master Ren: This Mei tree has ever been the root of our school, and now, it is the key to our greatest triumph.

Master Ren: We must protect it at all costs.

Master Ren: Now, on my command: Form the array.

School of Mei Believers: By nature's might, evil be purged!

School of Mei Believers: By nature's might, evil be purged!

As the believers channel their energy into the array, the ground shakes violently and a massive sinkhole opens around them, swallowing sand and stones. Soon after, water wells up from the pit, forming into a lake.

Golden rays shoot out from the lake, projecting daylight onto the clouds like a rising sun.

Master Ren: Ahahahaha. "The balance will be broken, and the sun and moon shall share the sky," so that's what the warning was about.

Master Ren: The beast has battled with the White Horse School for a millennium. But today, it will die by my hand.

Yam: But where is the beast?

Master Ren: Its body has long merged with the land. This very lake is its eye, the only part we may yet reach.

Master Ren: The time has come. Let it begin.

Master Ren: Through the might of all eight powers, we harness the flow of Qi!

Master Rén begins an incantation and chants. A typhoon erupts around her, whipping their new lake into a frothing whirlpool.

Beneath the golden shimmer, a Bagua array appears at the lake's edge, locking it down like a cage of light.

Master Ren: This Quelling Array has been the work of decades. Once it begins, there will be no escape for Lǎnzhū. Its death is certain.

Master Ren: With it, I will reach my goal, even without the sword.

Suddenly, Yam vanishes. In the smoke, a red light breaks through.

Paper Heron: Begone!

Master Rén leaps to dodge the attack, but Paper Heron's paper slips prove faster, and a few pieces tear at her robe's hem.

Master Ren: Stop her.

Badger: Yes, Master.

Several students form a defensive line. Long swords pointing out at the two.

Hedgehog: You'll have to get past us first, Heron.

Paper Heron: Stand back. I'm not here to fight you.

Yet the Yao don't move. They stare at Paper Heron expectantly.

Cheng Heguang: Take this!

Silver streaks flash in, breaking the standoff. The Yao are helpless to deflect the sudden barrage of needles.

Master Ren: Aghh!

Hedgehog: Master!

Though it was only a brief moment of distraction, Master Rén staggers against the immense pressure crushing down on her.

Badger: Hold the line!

Before the Yao can react, Chéng Héguāng drives his blade into the Quelling Array, seeking an opening to strike its core.

Master Ren: Agh! Protect the array!

Paper Heron: Stop this now, Rén! If the array shatters ...

Paper Heron: It will bring about your annihilation.

Master Ren: Enough talk.

Master Ren: There's nothing you can do to stop me. Get out of my way!

With an earth-shattering scream, Master Rén's body shrivels up like a burst grape. Blood-stained fragments scattering apart like Mei petals. The wind reveals her human form and buries the fallen believers.

Paper Heron struggles to reach Mayfly.

Paper Heron: Mayfly, you mustn't feed any more of your Qi to the array. You're draining yourself away.

Mayfly: I ...

She reaches out desperately, trying to pull her little friend to safety.

Yet Mayfly doesn't move.

Mayfly: I can't turn back now, Heron.

Struggling, she pulls the amulet from her pocket and lays it beside her along with that wrinkled note.

Mayfly: Thank you for helping me get this far.

Mayfly: I-I wanted this. I wanted to try. I have no regrets.

She slumps over, unable to even pull herself up, yet she raises her head and looks toward Paper Heron.

Master Ren: Good, sister. Let go now. Your wish has been fulfilled.

Master Rén struggles to her feet, clinging to the array, unwilling to abandon her chance at ascension.

The wind whips and howls around the lake. Then, as her Qi at last runs out, Mayfly's body collapses.

The amulet and note are swept up in the typhoon and torn to shreds.

Paper Heron: Mayfly!

Cheng Heguang: Heron, watch out!

She loses focus for only a moment, but it's enough time for several blades to strike at her. Chéng Héguāng whirls around and blocks them with the sheath of his blade.

Her strength fails her. Paper Heron suddenly feels as if the sword in her hand were as heavy as a mule.

Paper Heron: I ...

Black clouds press down against the sky. Thunder rolls. The earth tears open and slams shut. Sheets of coarse sand billow through the air. Huanzhou is lost.

Cries of anguish fill the streets. Even the constables can barely protect themselves. There is no place left to run.

Behind Master Rén, more Yao fall. Fox, Hare, Butterfly ...

Paper Heron looks to Mayfly's spot. Nothing remains there but a tuft of reeds, trampled by other frantic Yao.

What is lost can never be recovered.

Paper Heron: ...

Countless torn fragments swirl around, caught in the raging typhoon.

They drift past her like everything in the world always has, leaving nothing marked on her stone heart.

Paper Heron: Why?

Paper Heron: Why come all this way in seeking to extend your life, only to give it up so easily?

Paper Heron: Why must you come to this world, only to leave it so soon?

A question that might as well be asked to all living things.

She stands alone in the air, holding the Longevity Sword. The world around her has become a void of darkness.

Paper Heron: I spent so long trapped inside that tree that I forgot what it felt like to be a part of the world.

Paper Heron: Joy, sorrow, and pain became like distant memories.

Paper Heron: But what is this bitterness that racks my heart now?

She lowers her head and examines the sword in her hands.

Some of the Qi stored inside the Longevity Sword flows out into the array, pulled through the air like silk drawn from a cocoon.

Pearl Finch: Come, Heron, come. You must be starved after that detention. I've saved you some taro. Best not let the master see it.

Master: Cheeky little rascal. I hope no one finds out you were my student on your travels.

Master Ren: You-You saved my life. I swear I will repay you. I'll do whatever it takes.

Paper Heron: ...

Mayfly: So? How is it? Amazing, right? I told you it's delicious.

Mayfly: I-I wanted this. I wanted to try. I have no regrets.

White Horse School Students: Over here, Heron. Under the Mei tree.

Master: Remember, Paper Heron. In the end, we need only answer to our conscience.

The scenes she replayed countless times over a hundred years now vanish from her in a single moment.

Paper Heron tilts her head back, and a single tear shatters against the sheath.

Paper Heron: I understand now.

Paper Heron: It wasn't my isolation that numbed my senses. It was regret.

Paper Heron: For a hundred years, it was the only thing I knew.

She draws the Longevity Sword from its sheath, her hand slow and deliberate, revealing the white jade blade.

Paper Heron: The beast's rage has grown beyond control. Whether Rén ascends or not, Huanzhou will fall to ruin. Unless ...

All things return to their beginning.

Paper Heron: Master, now I understand why I survived.

Paper Heron: I have an unfinished purpose. And now, I will realize it.

She grips the Longevity Sword with both hands. A crack forms across the blade.

Paper Heron: Only one who witnessed the first seal as it was forged long ago can see this done.

Far beneath her, Master Rén takes notice of the change in her former teacher.

Master Ren: Heron, what do you think you're doing?

Master Ren: If you shatter the sword, those Yao will have died for nothing, and the White Horse School will be gone forever.

Yet the howling wind drowns out her cry.

Paper Heron: If the sword breaks, the Method of Longevity will die with it.

Paper Heron: And the legacy of the White Horse School will be forever lost.

Master Ren: Heron, you'll never forgive yourself for this.

Master Ren: Shatter the sword, and everything here will be sealed for another hundred years or more, your new friend included.

Cheng Heguang: Do it!

Cheng Heguang: If you believe it is necessary, do not hold back.

Master Ren: You're mad. How could you be willing to seal yourself into that tree again?

Paper Heron: For years, I have dwelled on the day my master shattered the first sword, trying to understand his thoughts, his fears, his hopes.

Paper Heron: My mind is set, even if I must give up my senses and become like stone again.

Paper Heron: Like him, once again, I will shatter the sword.

Paper Heron: And like him, once again, I will feel no regret.

Paper Heron: See you in a hundred years.

Goodbye, Friend

SU-21

Paper Heron: See you in a hundred years.

That familiar voice from a hundred years ago fades in the wind. Before the Mei tree, a figure materializes.

The image grows more solid and vivid, exactly as Reed saw in the memories.

Reed: Heron!

As her form solidifies, Reed can't suppress a gasp.

Reed: I-I get it now. Those Wind Knots were frozen by the power of the Longevity Sword, that's why the Windweave's been experiencing so much interference.

Reed: And Heron, she's been trapped here for all these years?

Mule: Bray!

The mule trots out happily, eager to bring its friends, old and new, together at last.

Seeing Reed frozen in place, it gently tugs at her, taking a blade of grass on her head into its mouth.

Paper Heron: Stop that. She's not a snack.

She laughs. The old mule reluctantly trots aside and lingers behind the Mei tree.

Paper Heron: It is good to finally see you in person, Reedit.

Paper Heron: I sincerely apologize for the trouble. There was little I could do from within the seal. You look well, though. I'm glad.

Reed: When you said you'd find me, I didn't think you meant like this.

Reed: It was you, wasn't it? The wind, the paper notes, you used them to guide me here, didn't you?

Paper Heron: I did. I believe you've seen this little Qi trick a few times by now.

Paper Heron: Within the seal, I was unable to communicate with the outside world, until those curious strings were put up.

She raises her finger and points first at the old Mei tree and then at the telephone pole standing next to its canopy.

Paper Heron: An odd Qi runs through them, one I found I could control. That's how I got on the forum.

Reed listens, making mental notes of her questions, until she arrives at a realization.

Reed: Strings? You mean the cables? You're telling me you can connect to the Internet through Qi?

Paper Heron: It is a remarkable technology. Though at times, the Qi would disappear.

Paper Heron: When that happened, I could no longer reach you.

Reed: Well, as much as I'd like to dive into it—I really, really would—let's save it for another time, kinda on a deadline here.

She stops and stares at Paper Heron.

Reed: I did what you asked, Heron. I untied all the knots.

Reed: Now it's time for you to hold up your end of the deal.

Reed: Only, you said that the Method would die along with the sword. So, you never really planned on passing it on to me, huh?

Reed: Or by "teach me," did you mean showing me your story in the Wind Knots?

She studies Reed. Her smile and tone are just as Reed remembers—light and warm.

Paper Heron: You are so very much like her.

Reed: Her?

Paper Heron: Mayfly. She too was a reed, sprouting in spring, withering by winter.

Paper Heron: And just like her, you move with haste in every single moment.

A name that they both know lingers in the air, stirring up memories and melancholy.

Reed: Mayfly ...

Paper Heron: That's why I reached out when I saw your post. Fate really seems determined to bring your kind to me.

Paper Heron: There's one last knot. I want you to be the one to undo it.

Reed: Another one? But didn't I already ...

Paper Heron: The story has yet to come to an end. The Method of Longevity didn't truly die with the sword.

Paper Heron: When I shattered it, I truly didn't expect I'd ever wake again. I thought the Method of Longevity would die with me.

Paper Heron: And even less that I'd be awakened by this new Qi.

With a sigh, she brushes the old Mei tree as if closing a door behind her.

Paper Heron: The sword may be gone, but it was nothing more than a vessel. Now that I've returned, the Method of Longevity lives on.

Paper Heron: And I shall pass it on to you, as thanks for your help.

Reed: ...!!!

Her heartbeat quickens in her chest.

Reed: I ...

Paper Heron: Don't be afraid. It sounds complicated, but it only takes a moment to grasp.

Paper Heron: You've returned me to life. Please, allow me to extend yours.

She smiles and extends her hand, then nods to Reed.

Paper Heron: Now, give me your hand.

The answer she has pursued across lifetimes finally within reach.

Yet now that it's here, Reed feels an inexplicable panic.

Reed: Are you ... Are you for real, like, really real?

Paper Heron: Having second thoughts?

Reed touches her own hair with anxiety. More blades of grass, each one growing yellower with each passing day, fall to the ground.

Paper Heron: I would never wish to pressure you. An offer like this could take time to process.

Paper Heron: Perhaps you feel differently about longevity now, after seeing what happened to Mayfly.

Paper Heron withdraws her hand and waits for Reed's answer.

Paper Heron: Do you still wish for more time in this world, little reed?

She reflects on the question for a long while. A moment later, she raises her head slowly and firmly.

Reed: I do.

Reed: I know my time's short, but I still have a life to live, just like anyone else, and I have the right to live as long as I can.

Reed: Even if it's hard, even if it's impossible, I can't stop just because I'm scared.

Reed: I want to live, to see more, write more, experience more.

Reed: I'll do anything to have one more day, one more hour, even one more minute to live.

She steps forward with growing certainty.

Reed: I know that the "me" who sprouts next spring will be "me" in some way, but she'll never be "me." My goals, my experiences, my thoughts, my work ... They'll be lost forever.

Reed: And even if that Reed continues to sprout across a thousand lives, it will never be me again.

Reed: So I'll keep looking, till my last leaves have withered away.

Reed: At least then, I can go without any regrets.

Paper Heron's response begins with surprise, but soon, her face adopts that familiar smile, serene and wistful.

Paper Heron: Well said!

Paper Heron: Many have held back for fear of the risks. It's rare to see someone with such remarkable courage.

Paper Heron: I am glad to have at last found the right person.

She extends her hand a second time, offering Reed a sincere invitation.

Paper Heron: Then repeat after me: In the vastness between heaven and earth, all things will bow to my measure.

Reed reaches for the ending and answer she has yearned for. Her fingers meet the rough bark.

Reed: In the vastness between heaven and earth, all things will bow to my measure.

Frozen wind cascades from her fingertips, then begins to flow.

Suddenly, the illusion before her eyes shatters. Another unexpected figure emerges from within, laughing.

???: Ahahaha ... Finally, after all this time!

The figure beneath the Mei tree brushes away the ash from her shoulder.

Reed steps back in shock. The name falters on her tongue, as if she's unable to believe it herself.

Reed: You-You're Rén!

Master Ren: Indeed. Now, come and pay respect to your master.

Reed: So it was you who sent those messages on the forum, not Heron?

Reed: And I've, I've just ...

Reed staggers, the depth of her mistake striking her with the force of a heavy blow.

Master Rén's smile grows mad and overwide, unconcerned by her fear.

Master Ren: There's no need to be afraid. I may have used Paper Heron's name to bring you here, but I did not lie about the Method of Longevity. I will guide you to it, if you wish.

She reaches for Reed's forehead.

But her hand meets nothing but air.

Reed: You-You did all this to bring me here, just to make me your student? Why?

Reed: What're you trying to do?

Her question is met with a mocking laugh.

Master Ren: Hmph. I had hoped you were wise enough to not mistake my kindness for malice.

Master Ren: All this fuss over a borrowed name, and yet you overlook the truth. I am your only hope to attain longevity.

Master Ren: Everything has a price. If longevity is what you desire, you must take the risk and pay it.

Master Ren: I came so close back then. Lǎnzhū would have been long dead if Heron hadn't stood in my way.

Master Ren: I never thought she would be mad enough to shatter her school's legacy just to seal me away.

The rising wind nearly swallows up her words.

Master Ren: So much time has passed. None who remember those days now live. Only you and I.

But now even the howl of the wind is lost beneath the roar of cracking earth.

Master Ren: All those lives wasted because of her!

Reed: You're not gonna ...

Ignoring Reed's shock, Master Rén flicks her sleeve sharply, and a patch of ground near the Mei tree's roots sinks.

Water surges from the cracks between rock and soil, carrying panicked fish along with it.

Master Ren: If those "cables" hadn't been built, I wouldn't have awoken so soon. For that, I am grateful.

Master Ren: Ahahaha ... I should thank you, too, for untying those knots and freeing me from the seal.

Master Ren: You see, unlike Master Heron, I ensure those who aid me are properly repaid.

Master Ren: Come here.

She yanks Reed close. Qi gathers in her right hand as she aims at the newly formed lake.

Leaves fall like rain from the tree as the earth buckles. Ripples bounce across the water.

And the water continues to rise.

Master Ren: Today the beast will fall, and I will ascend triumphant.

Reed: ...!

The lake overflows, soaking the parched yellow grass around it. The chaos of the scene matches the mounting panic surging through Reed's body.

Forgetting everything else, she grabs at Master Rén's arm.

Reed: Stop! You can't do this!

Reed: Rén!

She stumbles, almost falling into the lake.

Just as the visions showed, Lǎnzhū's eyes were once a lake at this very spot.

Now after centuries of slumber, it awakens.

Reed: I can't let her ...

The wind cries.

Reed: ... destroy the city.

A gale rushes toward the center of the lake.

Signs and awnings, bikes and roof shingles, everything the wind touches is pulled up in the rush.

Reed: I have to do something.

But she can't reach her.

It's too late now.

???: No need to worry.

Reed: Huh?

Somewhere in the groaning of the wind, she catches a faint, familiar voice.

???: Every creature, whether beast or man, wishes for more time in this world.

???: But know this: Those at their peak will decline, and those that have fallen will rise, for it is the Way to take from those in excess and give to those who lack. When Lǎnzhū sleeps, the world around it thrives; when it awakens, the world falls into ruin. All is in balance.

???: The workings of Heaven remain constant. There is no need to stop her.

Reed doesn't answer. She forces herself forward, the grass blades on her head bending flat against the fierce wind.

She strains with all her might, but Master Rén has already raised her hand, ready to strike.

Master Ren: It's too late. The beast ends today, and your mission with it.

Master Ren: Haaah!

Reed: Lǎnzhū has awakened.

Master Ren: The beast is weak. But my Qi, it flows out from me.

Master Ren: What have you done, Heron?

Master Ren: I will never ...

Master Ren: ...!

Paper Heron: Eight views merge, the mystery of Qi.

Paper Heron: Three lights darken, and all lose their way.

Long Time No See

SU-22

Mei Tree, Zhu County

The rising mist blurs everyone's vision, including that of a terrified, fleeing Critter.

A hand reaches in and lifts it up with ease, saving it from falling into the growing cracks.

Paper Heron: ...

She remembers when they first met. She had been just as miserable then as she is now.

A burning ozone smell hangs in the air. Paper Heron sits beneath the Mei tree and looks up.

The lightning is gone. She sighs in relief, then glances toward her feet.

Critter: *whimper*

A black fuzzball, weakened from multiple lightning strikes. Paper Heron looks down at it, pity welling up in her for the creature, despite everything.

Paper Heron: Psps, come here, little one, come.

Critter: ...?

Paper Heron: My master always said we should remember the good done to us and find ways to repay it.

Paper Heron: You drew that lightning to the Mei tree and freed me from my seal. Though it was an accident, I have reaped its benefits, and for that, I must give you my thanks.

Paper Heron: I have nothing of value save the Method. Here.

Paper Heron: Now, be on your way.

She releases the struggling Critter, and it runs swiftly into the distant grass before vanishing from sight.

Paper Heron raises her head. Another figure is walking toward her through the mist.

Reed: ...

The editor studies this new woman with a familiar face, cautious not to make the same mistake.

Reed: Paper Heron? Is that you?

Reed: Is it really you?

Mule: Whinny ...

The old mule, inexplicably safe despite all the calamity, trots over and whinnies affectionately.

Paper Heron pats its head and smiles at Reed.

Paper Heron: Yes, Reedit. It's the real me, this time.

Restaurant, Zhu County

The restaurant by the lake has only just opened for the day, but it's already packed with customers.

Visitors are willing to pay extra to see this new lake that appeared overnight.

Neighbor I: What did I tell you? This place is blessed. So many bright talents!

Neighbor I: See those reporters? We're gonna be on TV.

Neighbor II: So much for peace and quiet. I don't get it. What's so special about an old tree and a lake, anyway?

Waiter: Look on the bright side. Uncle Lǐ's been thinking about getting into the food business lately. With all these visitors, I bet he'll be moving into a big new house in no time. Isn't that right, Lǐ?

Neighbor I: Haha, sure is. When I've got the place settled, I'll have all of you over for a night of mahjong.

Waiter: We'll be there, and we won't go easy on you at the table.

Neighbor I: Do your worst. Hah-hah!

Guests at the corner tables take turns stealing conspicuous glances in their direction.

The waiter hurries over and sets down a plate of Fuliji Roast Chicken.

Reed: Thank you.

Waiter: Here on a visit? You don't look like you're from around here.

Waiter: We've been getting a lot of visitors lately. Just a heads-up: Watch out for the tourist traps, eh? Some of the souvenirs in the gift shops are pure rubbish.

Waiter: Ah, just look at that sword. Exactly what I mean. What a shame. Better off spending your money on local cuisine, I'd say.

Paper Heron: Appreciated! We just tried the duck and snail stew. Maybe Bāo Zhěng's fish next?

The waiter turns away. Paper Heron taps the sword gently, but any sound it might make doesn't rise above the chatter of the restaurant.

She lets her hand linger over the fractured blade, then picks up their conversation.

Paper Heron: So, what did you want to tell me, Reedie?

Reed: Err, it's not a big deal really. I just wanted to say it in person.

Reed: I'm sorry, Heron.

The words pour out bitter and regretful.

Reed: I shouldn't have fallen for Rén's trick. I knew something was off about her, but I-I guess I got greedy.

Reed: If you hadn't come to my rescue in time, I ...

Paper Heron: There, there. It's over now. We needn't worry about what's in the past.

She picks up the sword playfully, weighs it in her hand, then sets it down.

Paper Heron: Long ago, Qi flowed strong in the world, surging and rolling like ocean waves. But now, it has quieted.

Paper Heron: It no longer has the force to shake the plains or topple mountains, and the spells drawn from its power have lost much of their might.

Paper Heron: Lǎnzhū's power is much the same. That's why things didn't go Rén's way, even though she awakened the beast.

Paper Heron: When Lǎnzhū was strong, Rén could draw out its Qi to strengthen herself.

Paper Heron: But the flow of its Qi changed course. It draws in Qi rather than letting it flow out. A necessary balance. This is the Way.

Paper Heron: Lǎnzhū is unlikely to cause any disasters for a long time to come. You needn't worry.

She leans forward and offers a hand of comfort to Reed.

Paper Heron: Thanks to you, everything's finally settled. Though I can't help but take a little of the credit. I did do my best to guide you here.

Reed: Hm?

Reed: Hold on, so, then you really were the one who guided me here? You wanted me to set Rén free from the seal?

Paper Heron lets the question hang in the air, offering only a knowing smile at first.

Then she speaks, her answer delicately pruned and insightful.

Paper Heron: When I saw your post on the forum, I knew that you were a Yao, but I couldn't be sure of what you'd do until you showed up in person.

Paper Heron: Just like Mayfly, I knew you would take any risk to find the Method, and I realized Rén would seize on your desire and exploit it.

Paper Heron: You wouldn't be put off by what you saw in the Wind Knots; I knew you'd see it through to the end.

Paper Heron: So when Rén took my name to approach you on the forum, I didn't stop her, just like I didn't stop her from releasing Lǎnzhū.

Paper Heron: She would only be returning Qi to its rightful place, not disturbing it.

Her voice drops. After a brief pause, she continues.

Paper Heron: One gains, and the other loses. In the end, what's lost returns to where it is needed, and thus balance is maintained.

Paper Heron: Were it not for your resolve, none of this would have come to pass.

Paper Heron: And because all who took part in this—you, Rén, me—stood by each of our choices to the end ...

Paper Heron: What started hundreds of years ago could at last come to its rightful end.

Paper Heron: So you see, there's no need to apologize. All unfolded as fate intended.

Reed: I see.

Reed lets out a long breath. Her grass blades wilt on her head.

Reed: I haven't found longevity, but at least I found a story worth telling.

Reed: That's good enough for me.

She can't hide the sting of regret in her voice, but she buries it as best she can.

Yet Paper Heron seizes on it.

Paper Heron: There's a little more to it, actually.

Paper Heron: In the spring after Mayfly's death, a green shoot grew from the place where she last stood.

Paper Heron: When winter came, it withered, but in each following spring, a sprout grew anew.

Reed: ...!

Reed: You mean I'm ...?

Paper Heron: In a way, Mayfly's wish has been fulfilled.

Reed: Yeah.

Reed: I like this little epilogue.

Reed smiles as she closes her notebook.

Reed: I'm planning to write a couple more stories before winter comes.

Reed: I hope the "Reed" that sprouts next year likes them too.

Paper Heron: Hmm.

She frowns playfully.

Paper Heron: I must say, you're quite inquisitive for a reed.

Paper Heron: You'd likely make an excellent Daoist. Were you born in my time, many would have wanted you as their student.

Paper Heron: How about I—

Reed: Thanks for the offer, but I've always wanted to be a commissioning editor. I think I've had enough of Daoism for one lifetime!

They both laugh for a long while. Reed composes herself first.

She thinks for a moment, then extends an invitation.

Reed: But how about we take a walk around the Mei tree again?

Two figures approach the Mei tree. One crouches low; the other stands nearby.

Paper Heron looks up at the tree full of red blossoms and pats the bark as if greeting an old friend.

Paper Heron: This old thing will soon bloom more beautifully than ever.

The editor examines the stone bricks arranged around the tree, apparently recovered from some old houses that collapsed years ago.

A half-buried stone catches her attention.

Reed: This is ...

She bends down and brushes away the layer of dirt covering its face.

Paper Heron: Come on, Reedie.

Paper Heron: We'll still have some time if we take a shortcut to the streets.

Reed: Oh, sure!

The editor runs a few steps to keep up with her companion.

Reed: I've gotta report back to the office soon, tomorrow or at least by the day after.

Reed: What about you? What're you gonna do?

Paper Heron tilts her head, gesturing toward a tall building in the distance.

Paper Heron: I'll keep traveling. I seem to have missed a great deal over these last centuries.

Paper Heron: And, you know, my taste seems to have restored a little. Perhaps I'll search for a place with good food and stay there for a half-month.

Reed: I'd love to join you, if I still have time, that is.

Reed: You'll still be on the forum, right? The same account?

Paper Heron: Of course, and there's a friend I'd like you to meet, hm?

Cat: Meow.

The lake lies quiet as the wind laps gently over it, now a place where small creatures can gather to rest beneath the shade.

Paper Heron scoops up the fur ball and strokes its sleek coat.

Paper Heron: Hey, little one. Are you from around here?

Paper Heron: How about some fish for supper, hm?

Seeing the cat lounge contentedly beside them, Reed rests her hand on its back as well.

She remembers her last question.

Reed: A friend, huh? Someone else you met on the forum? Who are they?

Reed: Any idea what kinda food they like? There's a couple restaurants around here that look good.

Paper Heron: You needn't worry. He'll be grateful to eat anything, and in fact, you already know him.

Paper Heron: Last time, the seal took away my sense of taste, but his, at least, seems fine.

Paper Heron: He will have awakened by now. We can discuss it on the forum later.

Paper Heron: I have to say, the Internet is quite amazing, connecting people from all corners of the globe.

Reed: It sure is.

The editor gazes at the silver line where the lake meets the sky.

Reed: *blow*

She raises her arms, stretching her tense body.

Reed: So I got all worked up for nothing. But I guess I shouldn't complain.

Reed: There's no cataclysm, no raging beast, just a tree, a lake, and a gentle breeze over a quiet little path.

Paper Heron: Indeed.

She watches the fish as they bob up from the lake, surfacing one moment, diving deep the next.

One jumps up and vanishes away the moment it hits the water.

Paper Heron: It was all but a splash in the pond.